A DOCTORAL THESIS



An Economy *of Regard*

Theotrophy, the Morphean Paradox, and Custodial Enchantment in the Mythopoetics of Neil Gaiman

COMPARATIVE LITERATURE · MYTHOGRAPHY · PHILOSOPHY OF RELIGION

MMXXVI

In nova fert animus mutatas dicere formas corpora.

My mind is bent to tell of bodies changed into new forms.

OVID · METAMORPHOSES I.1–2

Cura enim quia prima finxit,
teneat quamdiu vixerit.

Because Care first shaped him, let Care hold him as long as he lives.

AFTER HYGINUS, FABULAE 220 · AS QUOTED BY HEIDEGGER

A DOCTORAL THESIS · COMPARATIVE LITERATURE · MYTHOGRAPHY · PHILOSOPHY OF RELIGION

Abstract

An Economy of Regard: Theotrophy, the Morphean Paradox, and Custodial Enchantment in the Mythopoetics of Neil Gaiman

This thesis argues that the fiction of Neil Gaiman—from *Violent Cases* (1987) and the seventy-five issues of *The Sandman* (1989–1996) through *American Gods* (2001), *Coraline* (2002), *Anansi Boys* (2005), *The Graveyard Book* (2008) and *The Ocean at the End of the Lane* (2013)—articulates a coherent, if deliberately unsystematic, speculative metaphysics, here named an *economy of regard*. Its governing premise is that being, in Gaiman's cosmos, is neither self-grounded nor merely projected but metabolically dependent upon attention: gods, persons, cities and stories persist insofar as they are believed, remembered, narrated or seen, and dwindle as that attention is withdrawn. Three axioms are reconstructed from the corpus. The *Axiom of Theotrophy* holds that every being is nourished by regard, so that ontology assumes the form of an economy with its own currencies, predators and bankruptcies (Chapters One and Four). The *Axiom of Metamorphosis* holds that because regard is itself mutable, whatever is regarded must change in order to go on being regarded; rigidity is a mode of starvation. Its tragic instance is formulated as the *Morphean Paradox*: the shaper of forms, whom Ovid invented as the *artifex simulatorque figurae* of the House of Sleep, becomes in Gaiman the one being who cannot alter his own form and whose only available metamorphosis is death and succession (Chapters Two and Three). The *Axiom of Custody* holds that because regard is finite and forgetting is the default condition of finite minds, the highest ethical act is fiduciary regard: the holding in trust of whatever attention has abandoned—the dead, the unseen, the unwritten, the forgotten self—for the sake of its eventual release (Chapters Five and Six).

From these axioms the thesis derives a master distinction between *capture*, an appetitive regard that holds a being for the holder's consumption, and *custody*, a fiduciary regard that holds a being for its own sake or the world's. The distinction is shown to be lodged in the vocabulary of watching itself—in the reconstructed Frankish *wardōn* that yields both *guardian* and *warden*, in the Latin *custodia* that signifies both protection and imprisonment, and in the Hebrew *shamar* that names Adam's first vocation and Cain's first refusal—and to organize the entire corpus, from the Corinthian's eye-devouring mouths to the Hempstocks' ocean, small enough to pass for a duck pond, in which a child's memories are kept in reserve. The ocular iconography of the oeuvre (Hoffmann's eye-thief, Odin's pledged eye, Coraline's buttons, blind Destiny) is read as the visible grammar of this economy. Gaiman's revisionist retellings are theorized, after Stesichorus, as *palinodes* that restore sight to figures whom earlier stories blinded (Chapter Seven), and his handling of suffering as a *theodicy of story* grounded in retellability rather than justification (Chapter Eight).

The argument proceeds comparatively, tracing the corpus to its originators—Hesiod, Plato, Ovid, Snorri Sturluson, Spenser, Shakespeare, Keats, De Quincey, Hoffmann, Frazer, Chesterton, Dunsany, Kipling and Borges—and situating it within the field of philosophical speculative fiction alongside Le Guin, Dick, Lem, Butler, Zelazny, Pratchett, Pullman, Chiang, Miéville, Ishiguro and Susanna Clarke (Chapter Nine). The synthesis (Chapter Ten) proposes that Gaiman's cosmos is Berkeley's after Nietzsche: a world in which *esse est percipi* still obtains but the divine Perceiver who once guaranteed the being of unperceived things has died, so that providence devolves upon finite regarders. Gaiman's fiction is accordingly read as the imaginative working-out of *devolved providence*, and his poetics as a *custodial enchantment* opposed, point for point, to the "captology" of the contemporary attention economy. The conclusion identifies Hyginus's fable of Cura—Care, who shapes the human from river clay and is awarded it for as long as it lives—as the mythic charter that the oeuvre never retells yet everywhere presupposes.

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PREFATORY NOTE

On Corpus, Method, and the Author-Function

The corpus of this study is the fiction Gaiman published between 1987 and the early 2020s, read as a single mythopoetic system rather than as a sequence of genre exercises. It comprises the comics and graphic novels (*Violent Cases*, *Black Orchid*, *Signal to Noise*, *The Sandman* with its specials, the two *Death* miniseries, *The Books of Magic*, *Miracleman: The Golden Age*, *The Tragical Comedy or Comical Tragedy of Mr. Punch*, *The Dream Hunters*, *Endless Nights* and *Overture*); the novels (*Good Omens*, written with Terry Pratchett, *Neverwhere*, *Stardust*, *American Gods*, *Anansi Boys* and *The Ocean at the End of the Lane*); the fiction for younger readers (*The Day I Swapped My Dad for Two Goldfish*, *Coraline*, *The Wolves in the Walls*, *The Graveyard Book*, *Odd and the Frost Giants*, *Fortunately, the Milk*); the short fiction gathered in *Angels and Visitations*, *Smoke and Mirrors*, *Fragile Things* and *Trigger Warning*; the retold *Norse Mythology* (2017); and, as secondary witness, the essays of *The View from the Cheap Seats* (2016). Film and television adaptations are treated as reception, not as text.

Because a large part of the corpus is sequential art, "Gaiman" in these pages names what Foucault called an author-function rather than a solitary consciousness. *The Sandman* in particular is a composite work whose meanings are inseparable from the pencils and inks of Sam Kieth, Mike Dringenberg, Malcolm Jones III, Kelley Jones, Jill Thompson, Charles Vess, P. Craig Russell, Marc Hempel and Michael Zulli, from Dave McKean's mixed-media covers, and from Todd Klein's lettering, which gives each of the Endless a typographic ontology of its own. Formal claims about panel, gutter and page draw on Will Eisner's *Comics and Sequential Art* (1985), Scott McCloud's account of closure in *Understanding Comics* (1993) and Thierry Groensteen's theory of *tressage* or braiding in *The System of Comics* (1999).

The method is comparative mythopoetics joined to philosophical hermeneutics. Genealogically, it traces Gaiman's motifs to the originators from whom they descend; comparatively, it sets them beside kindred speculative fictions; systematically, it reconstructs the implicit metaphysics that makes those motifs cohere. Paul Ricoeur's distinction between a hermeneutics of faith and a hermeneutics of suspicion is here supplemented by a third posture the argument itself recommends, a *hermeneutics of custody*, akin to Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's reparative reading and to Rita Felski's postcritique, which reads in order to keep rather than to unmask or to believe. Custody, however, is not credulity: a keeper who never inspects what he keeps becomes, as Chapter Five argues through the figure of the Sleer, a jailer. The study therefore alternates between reparative and suspicious modes, and several of its sharpest findings concern the places where the corpus fails its own ethic.

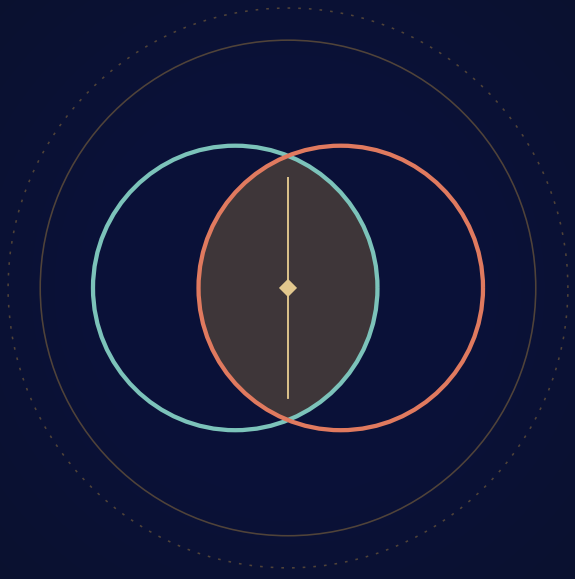
A note on quotation follows from the argument. Primary texts still in copyright are paraphrased rather than quoted; direct quotation is reserved for sources in the public domain, from Hesiod and the *Hávamál* to Keats's letters and Nietzsche's *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft*. A study that distinguishes custody from capture has reason to hold its own objects lightly, restating what they say without appropriating how they say it.

Finally, the author-function now carries a burden that no study written after 2025 can honestly omit. In July 2024 the British outlet Tortoise Media broadcast the accounts of two women who alleged that Gaiman had subjected them to sexual acts to which they had not consented; further women came forward in the following weeks; and in January 2025 *New York* magazine published the accounts of eight women. Their allegations are of rape, sexual assault, and coercive and degrading sexual conduct, in several cases within relationships of steep inequality: women decades younger than he was, admirers of his work, and, in one case, a young woman employed in his household to look after his son. Gaiman has publicly denied engaging in any non-consensual sexual activity. This thesis neither adjudicates those allegations nor recruits the fiction as evidence in either direction, since a novel can neither corroborate nor refute testimony about conduct. Roland Barthes's "The Death of the Author" (1967) and Foucault's "What Is an Author?" (1969) are invoked here as a discipline of reading, not as exculpation. The discipline has costs that should be named. The first falls on this study's own central term: several of the allegations concern people who stood in relations of dependence on him, which is the relation the corpus calls custody. Some texts, above all "Calliope" (*Sandman* #17), in which a novelist keeps the Muse locked in his house and rapes her repeatedly to extract his inspiration, are now widely reread in the light of the allegations, a reception history that no interpretation can dissolve; and the corpus's announced ethic of custody is, as Chapter Six shows, compromised within its own representational economy by the gendering of custodial labour. The analysis that follows takes the texts at their word precisely in order to measure how far their word reaches.

INTRODUCTION

The Etymological Fold

Regard, Ward, and Custody



To regard is etymologically to keep watch again, and the root names both the guardian who protects and the warden who confines.

The Sleeping King and the Hungry Gods

TWO images stand at the threshold of Gaiman's mature work, and together they contain its metaphysics. In the first, from the opening issue of *The Sandman* (1989), an English occultist attempting to trap Death in 1916 nets her younger brother instead, and for seventy-two years the lord of dreams sits naked in a glass sphere in a Sussex cellar while the waking world, deprived of its dreamer, sickens—Gaiman binds the fantasy to the historical epidemic of *encephalitis lethargica*, the "sleepy sickness" of 1915 to the late 1920s. In the second, from *American Gods* (2001), the deities carried to North America in the minds of migrants loiter in motels, strip clubs and roadside attractions, reduced to con men, cab drivers and undertakers because the people who once fed them with sacrifice now feed a new pantheon of media, technology and markets. The first image describes regard *seized*; the second, regard *withdrawn*. In both, the injury to the regarded being radiates outward into the world, because in Gaiman's cosmos nothing exists on its own account.

This thesis contends that these images are not ornamental premises but the visible surface of a coherent speculative ontology. Gaiman's fiction is organized by the conviction that to be is to be regarded, that regard is scarce, mutable and contested, and that the decisive ethical question is therefore not whether one attends but *how*: whether one holds what one sees for one's own appetite or in trust for its own sake. The first mode is here called *capture*; the second, *custody*. The distinction, it will be argued, sorts the entire corpus—its villains and guardians, its bargains and sacrifices, its retellings and endings—with a consistency that the existing criticism, organized around the monomyth, metafiction, feminist revision or the Gothic, has not registered.

The Fold in the Word

The distinction between capture and custody cannot be drawn by inspecting acts, because the acts are identical: both watch, both hold, both keep. The languages of Europe and the Levant record this identity with uncanny precision. English *regard* descends from Old French *regarder*, formed on *garder*, "to guard, to heed," from a reconstructed Frankish *wardōn*; the same root gives *guard* and *guardian*, *ward* and *warden*, and *reward*, which originally meant simply "regard" or "consideration." To regard is etymologically to keep watch again, and the root names both the guardian who protects and the warden who confines. Latin *custodia* signifies watch, care and protection, and equally the prison into which one is delivered, *in custodiam*; its *custos* is guardian and jailer at once, which is why Juvenal's question in the sixth satire—*quis custodiet ipsos custodes*?—remains the crux of every theory of guardianship. English *keep* means both to care for and to retain, and the *keep* of a castle, the Old French *donjon* or great tower of the lord's protection, gave English its *dungeon*: the refuge and the cell are one building seen from two floors.

The Hebrew Bible places the same root at the origin of the human vocation. In Genesis 2:15 the first human is set in the garden "to dress it and to keep it," *le'ovdah u-le-shomrah*, the verb *shamar* meaning to keep, guard, watch and observe; in Genesis 4:9 the first murderer answers the first moral question with the first repudiation of that vocation—"Am I my brother's keeper?", *ha-shomer 'aḥi 'anokhi*. Gaiman's Cain and Abel, adopted from the horror anthologies of DC Comics and resettled in the Dreaming, restage that repudiation eternally: Cain murders Abel, Abel revives, and the answer to the question is given again. From those anthologies Gaiman also inherits the arrangement by which Abel keeps the House of Secrets and Cain the House of Mystery, and he turns it into a quiet gloss on Genesis: the brother who keeps is the brother who is killed.

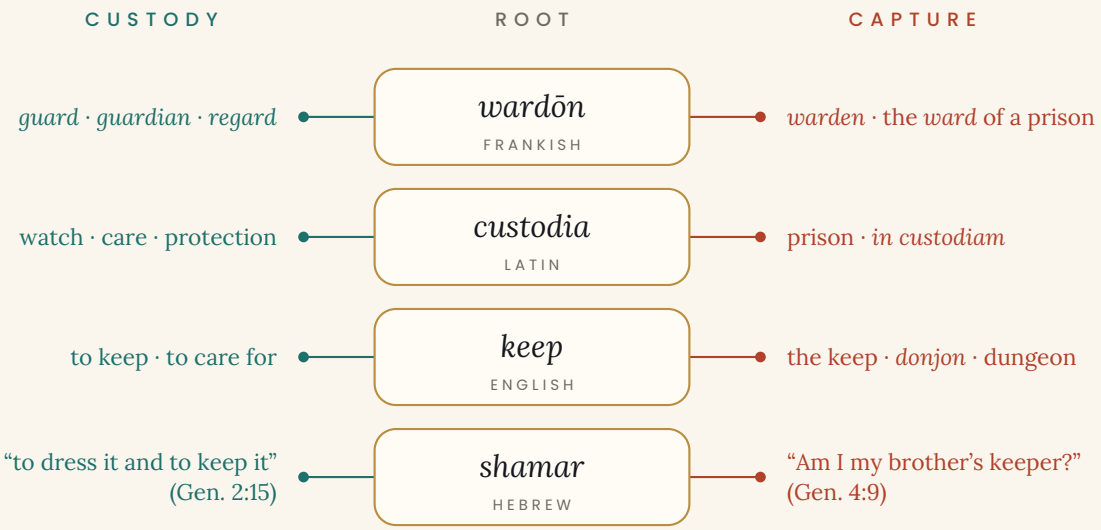


FIGURE 1 *The etymological fold. One root names the look that keeps and the look that confines; the two are told apart only by their end.*

Since the acts of capture and custody coincide, they must be discriminated by their *telos*. Capture holds a being for the holder's consumption; its end is the appetite of the one who watches. Custody holds a being for the sake of that being or of the world; its end is continuance, and its ultimate horizon is release. This study accordingly distinguishes *appetitive* from *fiduciary* regard. The latter term is chosen with care. *Fiduciary* derives from *fides*, faith understood as trust and fidelity rather than as propositional belief, and one of the claims of this thesis is that Gaiman's religious imagination performs exactly this substitution: it demotes belief-as-fuel, the credence on which the hungry gods of *American Gods* feed, and promotes fidelity-as-keeping, the faithfulness of the Hempstock women, of the dead of the graveyard, and of Death herself.

An Economy of Regard

The phrase *economy of regard* is borrowed from the economic historian Avner Offer, who used it in 1997 to describe the non-market circulation of attention, approval and esteem that underwrites gift exchange. Gaiman's fiction generalizes Offer's sociology into an ontology. Attention in his worlds is the substance of which beings are made, the currency in which they are paid, the resource over which they war, and the medium through which they are healed. The generalization has two intellectual lineages that rarely meet. The first is economic and critical: Herbert Simon's observation (1971) that an abundance of information produces a poverty of attention; Michael Goldhaber's "attention economy" (1997); Tim Wu's history of the attention merchants (2016); Shoshana Zuboff's surveillance capitalism (2019); and Jonathan Crary's argument in *24/7* (2013) that sleep is the last human interval not yet colonized by capital. The second is devotional and ethical: Simone Weil's claim that attention, fully unmixed, is prayer, and that attentive regard is the rarest form of generosity; and Iris Murdoch's development of Weil in *The Sovereignty of Good* (1970), where the moral life consists in a just and loving attention directed upon an individual reality, against the consoling fantasies of the ego.

Gaiman's corpus is the literary site where these two lineages converge. His predators are attention merchants, his nightmares feed on the regard of sleepers, his new gods are broadcast and network technologies, and his captivities are captivities of the gaze. But his guardians practise something indistinguishable from Weil's *attente* and Murdoch's unselfing: they wait, they watch, they keep, and they let go. The corpus thus stages, in mythic form, the central conflict of the early twenty-first century—between regard as extraction and regard as care—a decade and more before that conflict acquired its theoretical vocabulary.

> *The central conflict of the early twenty-first century: between regard as extraction and regard as care.*

The State of the Question

Gaiman criticism has been abundant and, within its frameworks, penetrating. Stephen Rauch's *Neil Gaiman's The Sandman and Joseph Campbell* (2003) reads the series through the monomyth; Hy Bender's *The Sandman Companion* (1999) and Joe Sanders's edited *The Sandman Papers* (2006) established its sources and structures; Annalisa Castaldo (2004) and Kurt Lancaster (2000) reconstructed its Shakespeare. Tara Prescott and Aaron Drucker's *Feminism in the Worlds of Neil Gaiman* (2012) and Prescott's *Neil Gaiman in the 21st Century* (2015) widened the field; Julia Round's *Gothic in Comics and Graphic Novels* (2014) placed the comics within a Gothic lineage. Around *Coraline* a small canon formed in 2008: David Rudd's "An Eye for an I," Richard Gooding's study of uncanniness and narrative form, Karen Coats's account of the psychic work of the Gothic, and Elizabeth Parsons, Naarah Sawers and Kate McInally's critique of the novel's postfeminist maternity.

This thesis draws on all of them, and on the general theory of fantasy supplied by John Clute's *Encyclopedia of Fantasy* (1997), with its grammar of *wrongness*, *thinning*, *recognition* and *return* and its figure of the *polder*; by Farah Mendlesohn's *Rhetorics of Fantasy* (2008), with its portal-quest, immersive, intrusion and liminal modes; and by Brian Attebery's *Stories about Stories* (2014) on fantasy's remaking of myth. None of these, however, has identified attention as the substance of Gaiman's ontology and the criterion of his ethics. Rudd's pun on eye and *I* comes closest, and Chapter Four extends it from one novel to the entire oeuvre.

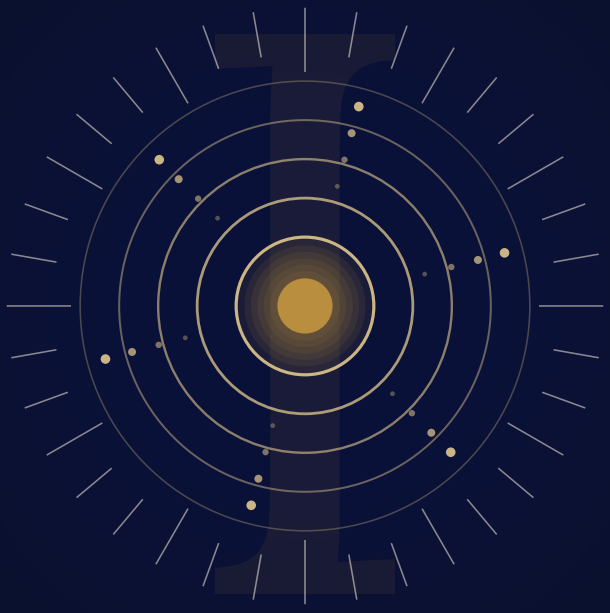
Architecture of the Argument

Chapter One reconstructs the genealogy of the dependent god from Xenophanes to William James and reads *American Gods* and *Anansi Boys* as treatises on theotrophy. Chapter Two returns Morpheus to Ovid and formulates the Morphean Paradox, reading *The Sandman* as the arc of a warden who must die to become a guardian. Chapter Three interprets the Endless as a table of the transcendental conditions of finite experience, organized around a vacant centre. Chapter Four assembles the ocular economy from Hoffmann to *Coraline*. Chapter Five theorizes custodial enchantment through *Neverwhere*, *The Graveyard Book* and *The Ocean at the End of the Lane*. Chapter Six describes the apophatic subject—the Nobody—who is the corpus's ideal regarder, and subjects its gendered labour to critique. Chapter Seven theorizes the palinode; Chapter Eight, the theodicy of story. Chapter Nine situates Gaiman among the philosophical speculative fictions of his century. Chapter Ten states the synthesis—devolved providence—and the Conclusion finds its charter in Hyginus.

CHAPTER ONE

Theotrophy

The Metabolism of the Dependent God



Once divine being is metabolically conditioned by regard, every act of attention becomes an act with ontological weight.

CHAPTER ONE · THEOTROPHY

THE claim that gods depend on their worshippers is among the oldest in Western thought; Gaiman's originality lies not in the premise but in its ethical consequence. Once divine being is metabolically conditioned by regard, every act of attention becomes an act with ontological weight, and the moral question of how one looks becomes indistinguishable from the metaphysical question of what there is. This chapter names that condition *theotrophy* (from θεός, god, and τροφή, nourishment), reconstructs its genealogy, and reads *American Gods* and *Anansi Boys* as its fullest literary treatises.

1.1 A Genealogy of the Dependent God

The genealogy begins with Xenophanes of Colophon, who observed in the sixth century BCE that the Ethiopians make their gods snub-nosed and dark and the Thracians make theirs blue-eyed and red-haired, and that horses, could they draw, would draw gods like horses (fragments B15–B16). Xenophanes meant the observation as a critique of anthropomorphism; its latent implication—that the shape of the divine is supplied by the regard of the worshipper—is Gaiman's starting point. Euhemerus, some two centuries later, supplied the complementary hypothesis that the gods were once human beings elevated by commemoration, and it was a euhemerizing Christian, Snorri Sturluson, who transmitted Norse myth to modernity. The Prologue to Snorri's *Edda* (c. 1220) presents the Æsir as men of Asia descended from Troy, and the *Gylfaginning* frames the whole mythology as a deception practised on the Swedish king Gylfi: when the interview ends he hears a great noise and finds himself on an empty plain, hall and castle gone. Norse myth enters written literature, that is, as an illusion staged by those who stand to be worshipped for it. *American Gods*, whose Odin is a grifter orchestrating the largest confidence trick in the novel, is in this respect a remarkably faithful reading of its source.

The modern phase of the genealogy is a sequence of reductions that Gaiman inherits and then refuses. David Hume's *Natural History of Religion* (1757) described a perpetual "flux and reflux" between polytheism and theism; *American Gods* stages a reflux, a new polytheism of media, markets and machines. Ludwig Feuerbach's *Das Wesen des Christentums* (1841) held that God is the human essence projected and alienated, so that the secret of theology is anthropology. Marx found the same structure in the marketplace, observing in the first volume of *Capital* (1867) that a commodity, apparently trivial, proves on analysis to be "a very queer thing, abounding in metaphysical subtleties and theological niceties." Durkheim's *Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912) identified the god of the clan with the clan itself, hypostatized in the totem and recharged in episodes of collective effervescence. And William James, in

"The Will to Believe" (1896), argued that there are cases "where faith in a fact can help create the fact"—the most exact philosophical anticipation of Gaiman's premise, since it makes belief a partial cause of what is believed rather than merely a mirror of it.

The decisive text, however, is Nietzsche's. In section 125 of *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* (1882) the madman announces that God is dead and that we have killed him. Seventeen sections earlier, under the heading "Neue Kämpfe," Nietzsche had written the sentence that *American Gods* unfolds into a novel: "Gott ist todt: aber so wie die Art der Menschen ist, wird es vielleicht noch Jahrtausende lang Höhlen geben, in denen man seinen Schatten zeigt"—God is dead, but given the way of men there may be caves for thousands of years in which his shadow is shown. Gaiman's protagonist is named Shadow; he is revealed to be the son of the one-eyed god whose confidence trick drives the plot; and the sacred sites of the novel are precisely the caves in which the shadows of dead gods are displayed—the House on the Rock, Rock City, the backstage of a carousel. The name condenses three lineages at once: Plato's cave, in which prisoners take shadows for realities; Jung's shadow, the disowned remainder of the personality; and Nietzsche's cave, in which the corpse of divinity continues to cast a shape. Shadow Moon is the shadow of the dead god learning to become a person, and his surname, which names a body that shines only by reflected light, completes the figure.

One further figure in the novel shows that theotrophy extends to scholarship itself. Gaiman's Easter is among the few old gods who prosper, because her name persists in a festival even though almost no one knows it is a name. The historical goddess Ēostre is attested in exactly one place, a sentence in Bede's *De temporum ratione* (725) explaining the name of the month *Eosturmonath*; Jacob Grimm reconstructed her as *Ostara* in his *Deutsche Mythologie* (1835); and a century of folklorists fed the reconstruction. Easter is a deity nourished by philology. The implication is not lost on a thesis about gods: commentary is a form of worship, and criticism, too, is theotrophic.

> *Easter is a deity nourished by philology.*

1.2 Abaliety: A Dependent Realism

The position that results is neither Feuerbach's nor classical theism's, and it needs a name. Scholastic theology defined God by *aseitas*, being from oneself (*a se esse*), and set against it the *abalietas*, being from another (*ab alio esse*), of every creature. Gaiman's gods are abalietous. They are real—they act, suffer, bargain, murder and outlive any particular worshipper—so the Feuerbachian reduction does not hold. But their persistence is conditioned by a regard they cannot supply for themselves, so the Anselmian perfection does not hold either. This is a *dependent realism*, distinct from projection, which denies the reality of what is projected, and from social constructivism, which denies that what is constructed can turn upon its constructors.

The Dreaming obeys the same law. It is shaped by those who dream, and its lord exists as a function of the fact that living things dream at all. The nearest philosophical analogue is not Western but Indian. Vasubandhu's *Viṃśatikā* (fourth or fifth century CE) uses the phenomenology of dream to argue that experience requires no external object, and Yogācāra thought locates the seeds of all experience in an *ālaya-vijñāna*, a storehouse consciousness that is, structurally, a Dreaming. Madhyamaka thought, from Nāgārjuna onward, extends dependence to everything: no phenomenon possesses *svabhāva*, intrinsic self-nature, and all arise in dependence on conditions. Gaiman's cosmos is, in this precise sense, a cosmos without aseity anywhere. Even the Endless, as Chapter Three shows, depend on the existence of the living. The Western precursor closest to this position is Jung's *Antwort auf Hiob* (1952), whose God achieves consciousness only through the moral consciousness of the creature he has wronged: a divinity nourished by human regard in the most intimate sense.

1.3 The Anatomy of Hunger: American Gods

American Gods is organized as a survey of the economy that dependent realism produces. Its interchapters, headed "Coming to America" and framed as the writings of Mr. Ibis, record the arrival of gods in the minds of migrants: Viking sailors who hang a captive to Odin on a shore in Vinland; a Cornish transportee who carries her belief in piskies and small folk; the enslaved twins Wututu and Agasu, through whose captivity the loa cross the Middle Passage; an Omani salesman who exchanges lives with an ifrit driving a New York taxi; and, earliest of all, a Siberian people whose mammoth-skull god, Nunyunnini, simply ceases when its people adopt others. That last vignette states the law of the novel in its purest form: a god dies of being forgotten, without violence, as a flame dies for want of air.

It matters that the recorder of these arrivals is Thoth, the ibis-headed inventor of writing. In the *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), Theuth presents his invention to King Thamus, who replies that "this discovery of yours will create forgetfulness in the learners' souls, because they will not use their memories." Gaiman answers Thamus through Thoth himself: Mr. Ibis's writing is custodial, the only archive in which the migrations of gods, and of the enslaved people who carried some of them, are kept. The vignette of

Wututu and Agasu belongs with Paul Gilroy's *The Black Atlantic* (1993) and Saidiya Hartman's *Lose Your Mother* (2007), because it describes the limiting case of the economy of regard: custody practised under conditions of absolute capture, in which people who owned nothing else kept their gods alive in the hold of a ship. Mr. Ibis and his colleague Mr. Jacquel, Anubis, run a funeral parlour in Cairo, Illinois, and Anubis still weighs the hearts of the dead against a feather, as in spell 125 of the Egyptian *Book of the Dead*: the novel's first custodians are undertakers and scribes.

Against them stand the new gods, each a precise figure of captured attention. Media speaks from a motel television in the borrowed shape of Lucy Ricardo and describes the screen, in effect, as an altar on which viewers sacrifice their time. The novel here dramatizes Marshall McLuhan's dictum that the medium is the message (1964) and Neil Postman's diagnosis in *Amusing Ourselves to Death* (1985) that television reorganizes a culture's epistemology around entertainment. The Technical Boy, adolescent, insecure and cruel, is the god of networked computation; his successors are recognizably the platforms that Zuboff would describe eighteen years later. The markets are represented by the Intangibles, heirs of the "invisible hand" by which Adam Smith's merchant is "led … to promote an end which was no part of his intention" (*Wealth of Nations*, IV.ii.9): the most successful god of modernity is the one that is never seen. And the spooks—Mr. Town, Mr. Wood, Mr. Stone—are the agents of a surveillance that watches without ever being watched.

The novel's primal scene of appetitive regard belongs, however, to an old goddess. Bilquis, the Queen of Sheba reduced to working as a prostitute, takes her worship through sex: during the act she absorbs her clients wholly into her body, and they vanish. The metaphor of devotion as consumption is literalized as sexual consumption, and her subsequent murder at the Technical Boy's instigation marks the transfer of appetite from the old economy to the new. Theotrophy, in other words, is not a benign mutualism. It can be predation, and the difference between predation and nourishment is the difference this thesis calls capture and custody.

The sacred geography of the novel extends the analysis. Mircea Eliade described sacred space as the site of a *hierophany*, an irruption of the sacred that founds a world around an *axis mundi*. Gaiman relocates the hierophany into kitsch. The House on the Rock in Spring Green, Wisconsin, with its infinity room, its automata and what the novel calls the world's largest carousel, is a place of power precisely because it is a monument to fascinated, undirected attention; riding the carousel translates Shadow into the backstage of the gods, so that the *axis mundi* becomes a merry-go-round. Umberto Eco's "Travels in Hyperreality" (1975), with its catalogue of America's wax museums and replicated masterpieces, and Jean Baudrillard's *Amérique* (1986) diagnosed the same landscape as a regime of the absolute fake. Gaiman accepts the diagnosis and reverses its valence. The fake is where the sacred now pools, because it is where regard is concentrated.

The plot then exposes the economy's deepest possibility, which is that belief can be farmed. Wednesday and Loki engineer a war between the old gods and the new so that its dead may be dedicated to Odin, as Norse warriors once dedicated an enemy host by

casting a spear over it. Both pantheons are, in this light, instruments of a single capture. Shadow ends the war not by fighting but by telling each side what it is being used for: revelation functions as release. The same structure governs the Lakeside episode, in which a kobold drawn from the sixteenth-century legend of Hinzelmann keeps a Wisconsin town prosperous by murdering one child every winter and hiding the body in the car that the townspeople bet on as it sinks through the lake ice. Lakeside is Le Guin's Omelas moved to the upper Midwest, and Shadow responds neither by consenting nor by walking away but by recovering the dead, which is to say by remembering. Chapter Nine returns to the comparison.

The novel's custodial ethic falters at one point, and the failure is instructive. Its vision of the land itself—the buffalo-headed man of Shadow's dreams, Whiskey Jack's insistence that the land's own spirits preceded the imported gods and will outlast them—assigns Indigenous presence the role of metaphysical ground rather than political subject. Philip J. Deloria's *Playing Indian* (1998) and Jodi Byrd's *The Transit of Empire* (2011) supply the terms of the critique: a settler imagination that keeps Indigeneity in the register of timeless spirit forecloses its claims in historical time. By the thesis's own criterion, this is custody that has not yet learned to release.

1.4 Anansi Boys: The Custody of Stories

Anansi Boys (2005) is theotrophy's comedy, and its god thrives because he requires no sacrifice, only retelling. In the Akan tradition from which Anansi comes, the stories of the world belong at first to the sky-god Nyame, and Anansi purchases them by capturing four creatures—Onini the python, Osebo the leopard, the Mmoboro hornets and the fairy Mmoatia—after which all stories are *anansesem*, spider stories. The founding act of narrative ownership is thus an act of capture turned by wit to the benefit of the powerless. Gaiman's version transfers the stories from Tiger, whose tales were of appetite and dominion, to Anansi, whose tales are of the weak outwitting the strong: a mythic redistribution of regard from predator to trickster. Paul Radin's *The Trickster* (1956), with its commentaries by Jung and Kerényi, Lewis Hyde's *Trickster Makes This World* (1998) and Henry Louis Gates Jr.'s *The Signifying Monkey* (1988) together describe the figure who presides over this redistribution: the boundary-crosser whose mischief makes culture possible and whose signifying turns the master's language against him.

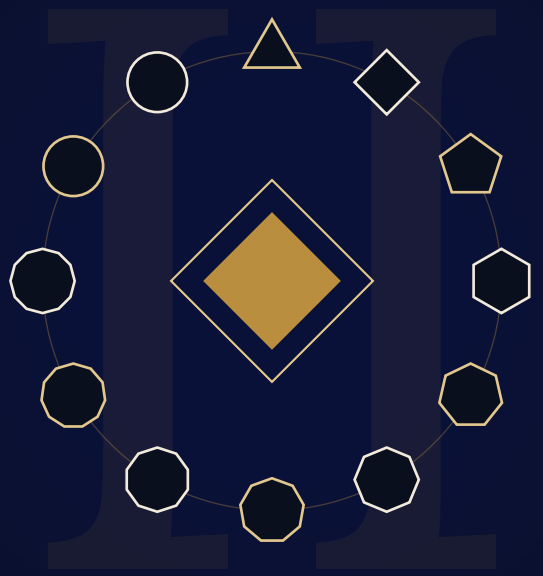
Fat Charlie Nancy, the god's son, suffers from regard of the paternal kind. His nickname is his father's joke, and it fixes him as a name fixes an animal in Adam's garden. His double, Spider, is the divine half of his inheritance split off into a separate person, a Hoffmannian *Doppelgänger* rendered as romantic comedy. The resolution comes when Charlie sings: the recovery of voice is the recovery of self from a name imposed by another. The novel's custodians, meanwhile, are four elderly women in Florida who keep Anansi's memory and conduct his rites, and its predator is a literary agent, Grahame Coats, who embezzles his clients' earnings. Capture in *Anansi Boys* takes the form of theft of regard in its financial sense, and custody the form of old

women remembering. The thesis of the book is that the god who survives best is the god who has become a story, a claim whose full implications belong to the next chapter: to be told is to be changed, and to be changed is to go on.

CHAPTER TWO

The Morphean Paradox

Ovid's Shaper and the Law of Metamorphosis



The being Ovid created to wear every face becomes, in Gaiman, the one being who cannot alter his own.

CHAPTER TWO · THE MORPHEAN PARADOX

THE protagonist of *The Sandman* is borrowed from a poem whose single subject is change, and the tragedy of the series is that he alone cannot change. This chapter returns Morpheus to his Ovidian origin, reconstructs the law of metamorphosis that governs Gaiman's cosmos, and reads the seventy-five issues as the arc of a warden who must die in order to become a guardian.

2.1 Ovid's Shaper

Morpheus is Ovid's invention. In the eleventh book of the *Metamorphoses* (c. 8 CE), Juno sends Iris to the House of Sleep, a lightless cave in the country of the Cimmerians beneath which, Ovid specifies, a stream of Lethe runs from the base of the rock (*saxo tamen exit ab imo / rivus aquae Lethes*, XI.602–3). There Somnus rouses, from among his thousand sons, the one he calls *artificem simulatoremque figurae / Morphea* (XI.634–5): the craftsman and simulator of shape, who counterfeits the faces, gait, voice and clothing of human beings. His brothers divide the rest of appearance between them—Icelos, whom mortals call Phobetor, takes the forms of beasts; Phantasos, those of earth, rock, water and wood. Morpheus is sent to Alcyone in the likeness of her husband Ceyx, drowned at sea, to tell her that he is dead; and the episode ends with the transformation of both lovers into kingfishers, whose calm winter nesting gives English its *halcyon days*.

Four features of this origin anticipate Gaiman with startling exactness. The first Morpheus is an artist of simulation, the originary *simulator* of whom Baudrillard's simulacra are late descendants. His first narrative errand is to carry news of a death, so that Dream serves Death at the very moment of his invention—the sibling bond of Gaiman's Endless is already present in Ovid's plot. His house stands upon Lethe, so that dreaming is founded on forgetting. And he belongs to a poem that announces its subject in its first line as bodies changed into new forms: *in nova fert animus mutatas dicere formas / corpora* (I.1–2). The name itself, from μορφή, form, makes him the Shaper; among the names by which Gaiman's characters address him are Oneiros, Kai'ckul and Lord Shaper.

The irony that organizes *The Sandman* follows directly. The being Ovid created to wear every face becomes, in Gaiman, the one being who cannot alter his own. He is formal, proud, punctilious in his obligations, incapable of apology, and bound by the rules of his realm to a degree that his siblings find absurd. This thesis names the resulting structure the *Morphean Paradox*: the shaper of forms cannot receive a new form without ceasing to be the being whose office is the giving of forms. The paradox is the tragic instance of a general law, which must now be stated.

2.2 The Law of Metamorphosis

The second axiom of Gaiman's economy holds that whatever is sustained by regard must change in order to go on being regarded, because regard is itself mutable. Attention drifts; belief migrates; cultures forget. A being that insists on the form in which it was first attended will be attended less and less, and in a theotrophic cosmos diminishing attention is diminishing being. The old gods of *American Gods* who refuse to adapt starve; Easter, whose name has migrated into a festival, and Anansi, who has migrated into stories, prosper. Rigidity is a mode of starvation.

The law has a long philosophical ancestry. Heraclitus, as Plato reports him in the *Cratylus* (402a), held that all things move and nothing stays, so that one cannot step twice into the same river. Lucretius argued that nothing is created from nothing and nothing is reduced to nothing, so that the things that seem to perish do not wholly perish (*haud igitur penitus pereunt quaecumque videntur*, I.262). Ovid gives the doctrine to Pythagoras in the fifteenth book of the *Metamorphoses* in its most compact form—*omnia mutantur, nihil interit* (XV.165), all things change, nothing dies. And Spenser, in the *Two Cantos of Mutabilitie* appended to *The Faerie Queene* (1609), stages a trial in which Mutability claims sovereignty over the gods and Nature delivers a verdict that reconciles change with identity: all things, she finds, "stedfastnes doe hate / And changed be: yet being rightly wayd / They are not changed from their first estate; / But by their change their being doe dilate" (VII.vii.58).

Spenser's verdict is precisely the doctrine that Destruction teaches his brother in *Brief Lives* (1992–93). The Endless, he argues, are patterns rather than persons; the functions they embody persist whether or not anyone embodies them, so that destruction continued in the world after he abandoned his realm at the close of the seventeenth century, when he foresaw that human reason was about to assume responsibility for destroying things; and what persists through change is not a substance but a shape of recurrence. The Pythagorean *nihil interit* is thus put, with deliberate paradox, into the mouth of the lord of destruction. The series' own motto—that one must change or die—is a Spenserian dilation stated as an ultimatum.

The early 1990s produced a remarkable convergence on this law. In 1992 Terry Pratchett published *Small Gods*, whose Great God Om has dwindled to a tortoise because only one man still truly believes in him. In 1993, the year *Brief Lives* concluded, Octavia E. Butler published *Parable of the Sower*, whose Earthseed verses identify God with Change itself and make the deliberate shaping of change the religious act. Three writers working in different registers—comic fantasy, Afrofuturist prophecy and mythic comics—arrived within months of each other at a theology in which persistence requires transformation. Gaiman's distinctive contribution is to make the law tragic by embodying it in a being constitutionally unable to obey it.

The corpus is careful to establish that Dream's rigidity is chosen rather than necessitated. His youngest sibling was once Delight and became Delirium; the first Despair died and was replaced; Destruction simply walked away; and *Overture* (2013–15) reveals that Dream himself exists in innumerable aspects across the universe.

The Endless can change. The Morphean Paradox is therefore ethical, not metaphysical: Dream is faithful to his own form to the point of captivity, the warden of himself.

2.3 From Warden to Guardian

Read in this light, *The Sandman* describes a single moral trajectory. Released from Roderick Burgess's sphere, Dream practises custody in its carceral sense. His justice is punitive and exquisitely fitted: Alex Burgess is condemned to eternal waking, a sleep of unending nightmare that realizes Dante's principle of *contrapasso* (*Inferno* XXVIII.142) with the captor made captive of sleep; the novelist Richard Madoc, who imprisoned the Muse Calliope and raped her repeatedly, is flooded with ideas until he cannot hold them; and Nada, the queen who refused his love ten thousand years earlier, has spent those ten thousand years in Hell because he condemned her there for the refusal. The one metamorphosis Dream performs freely in these early issues occurs in play: in Hell he defeats the demon Choronzon in "the oldest game," a duel of transformations of the kind preserved in the Welsh chase of Gwion Bach and Ceridwen and the ballad of "The Two Magicians," and he wins by naming hope when his opponent names anti-life. The victory is Ernst Bloch's *Prinzip Hoffnung* expressed as a move in a game; it also shows that Dream can metamorphose when nothing he values is at stake.

The arc bends through a sequence of releases. In "Men of Good Fortune" (#13), meeting the immortal Hob Gadling once a century in the same tavern, Dream learns what Aristotle, in the eighth book of the *Nicomachean Ethics*, thought nearly impossible: friendship across radical inequality. In "Calliope" (#17) he frees the Muse he had once abandoned. In *Season of Mists* he descends to Hell to release Nada, is given the key of Hell by an abdicating Lucifer, and gives it away rather than become the jailer of the damned. In "A Midsummer Night's Dream" (#19) the play he commissions from Shakespeare is performed for Auberon and Titania so that the departing Faerie may be remembered by the mortal world—art as custody of what is leaving—though the cost falls on Shakespeare's neglected son Hamnet. And at the end of *Brief Lives* he grants his son Orpheus, whose severed head has sung for millennia, the death Orpheus asks for.

That last act of mercy is also the spilling of kin-blood, and it delivers Dream to the Furies. *The Kindly Ones* takes its title from the Athenian euphemism *Eumenides*, and its structure inverts Aeschylus. In the *Oresteia* (458 BCE) the Erinyes who pursue the matricide Orestes are persuaded by Athena to accept a court, the Areopagus, in place of blood-vengeance, and are renamed the Kindly Ones in token of their domestication. In Gaiman there is no Athena; the archaic law reasserts itself, and Dream, far from resisting it, has arranged the conditions under which it will take him. The Hegelian account of tragedy as the collision of two rights—the law of the family against the law of the community—is realized with unusual purity, because Dream's transgression and his mercy are the same act. Critics have debated whether to read his end as sacrifice, as a willed death or as metamorphosis; the argument here is that the question

dissolves once succession is understood as the only form of change the Shaper can undergo.

The mythic template for that succession is Frazer's. *The Golden Bough* (1890) opens at Nemi, where the priest-king of Diana's grove prowls with drawn sword around a sacred tree: "He was a priest and a murderer; and the man for whom he looked was sooner or later to murder him and hold the priesthood in his stead." Dream's successor is Daniel, the child conceived in the Dreaming, whose mother Lyta Hall becomes the unwitting instrument of the old king's death. Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920) supplies the complementary figure of the wounded Fisher King whose injury lays waste his land, which is exactly what Dream's captivity did to the world's sleep in 1916. And the *Hávamál* supplies the formula for a death that is at once suffered and chosen. Odin hangs nine nights on the windy tree, wounded with a spear, "offered … / To Othin, myself to myself" (st. 138, trans. Bellows, 1923). Morpheus's death is an offering of the function to itself.

The relation between Morpheus and Daniel is neither identity nor replacement, and the best account of it comes from outside the Western canon. In the *Milindapañha*, the monk Nāgasena explains rebirth to King Milinda through the image of a flame lit from one lamp to another: the new flame is *na ca so na ca añño*, neither the same nor another. Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) reached the same conclusion analytically, arguing that personal identity is not what matters in survival and that psychological continuity can hold without it. Daniel inherits Dream's office, memory and realm without being Morpheus; he is dressed in white where his predecessor wore black. And his first significant act is custodial: he takes under his protection the woman whose vengeance destroyed his predecessor. The warden could not become a guardian; his successor begins as one.

> *The warden could not become a guardian; his successor begins as one.*

2.4 The Drowned Book

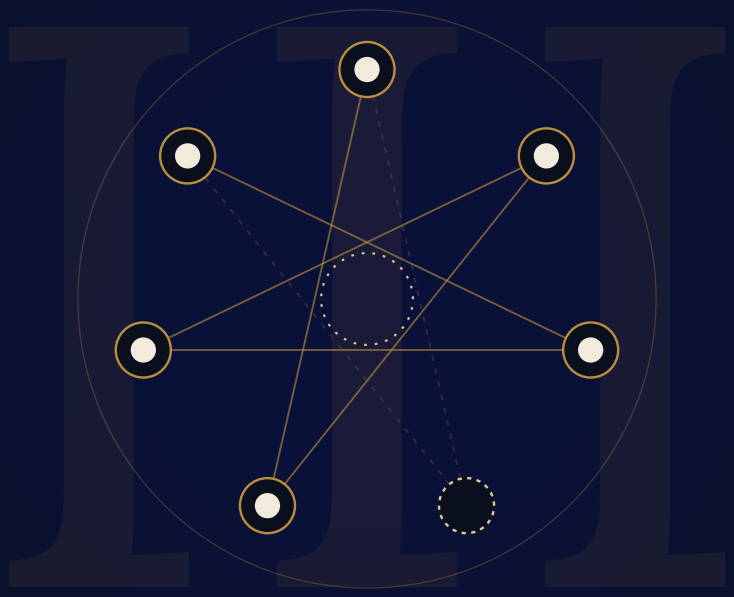
The series ends with Shakespeare. “The Tempest” (#75) shows the playwright in Stratford around 1610, completing the second of the two plays owed under the bargain struck in “Men of Good Fortune.” Asked why he wanted a play about a magician who abjures his magic, Dream confesses, in effect, that he is the lord of stories who has no story of his own, and that he desired a tale about a king who leaves his art behind because it is the one thing he himself can never do. Prospero’s abjuration—“I’ll break my staff, / Bury it certain fathoms in the earth, / And deeper than did ever plummet sound / I’ll drown my book” (V.i.54–57)—becomes the proxy through which the Shaper performs the metamorphosis forbidden to him. His most famous lines—“We are such stuff / As dreams are made on, and our little life / Is rounded with a sleep” (IV.i.156–58)—become a gloss on the entire series.

The sequence also answers Borges. In “Everything and Nothing” (1958), Borges imagined Shakespeare as a man who was no one, who spent his life impersonating others and who, at death, asked God to let him be one person; God replied that He too was no one, having dreamt the world as Shakespeare dreamt his work. Gaiman’s Shakespeare is similarly hollowed by his gift, and his Dream similarly lacks the one story that would make him someone. But where Borges ends in a vertiginous mutuality of nobodies, Gaiman ends in custody. The play keeps what its commissioner cannot live, and in keeping it for him, it outlives him. Chapter Five will argue that this is the general function of art in the corpus: to hold in trust the lives, deaths and impossibilities that their subjects cannot hold for themselves.

CHAPTER THREE

The Seven Conditions

The Endless as a Table of Finite Experience



The organizing principle of the whole is an empty chair.

CHAPTER THREE · THE SEVEN CONDITIONS

THE Endless are neither gods nor allegories but the conditions under which finite, conscious life is possible, given faces. This chapter traces their genealogy through the tradition of personified abstraction, proposes that the seven siblings constitute a mythic analogue of Kant's table of transcendental conditions, identifies the vacancy at the centre of their family, and examines the two whose functions frame every life: Death and Destiny.

3.1 A Genealogy of Personified Abstraction

The tradition Gaiman inherits is long. Prudentius's *Psychomachia* (c. 405) set the virtues and vices at war for the soul. The morality play *Everyman* (c. 1510) sent Death as God's messenger to summon its hero, whom Fellowship, Kindred and Goods abandon and only Good-Deeds accompanies to the grave. Spenser's pageants of the seasons and months made time itself processional. The Romantic period transformed the mode. Blake's unfinished *Vala, or The Four Zoas* (c. 1797–1807) dismembered the Universal Man, Albion, into four warring faculties—Urizen, reason; Luvah, passion; Tharmas, sensation; Urthona, whose fallen form is Los, imagination—so that cosmic catastrophe became a quarrel among the powers of a single psyche. And Thomas De Quincey, in "Levana and Our Ladies of Sorrow" (*Suspiria de Profundis*, 1845), produced the most exact nineteenth-century prototype of Gaiman's family: three sister-goddesses of grief, differentiated in temperament and terror, who haunt every human dwelling. "The eldest of the three is named Mater Lachrymarum, Our Lady of Tears"; the second is Our Lady of Sighs; the youngest and most terrible, Our Lady of Darkness.

Gaiman's immediate peers worked the same seam. Terry Pratchett's Death, an anthropomorphic personification speaking in small capitals, had appeared in 1983 and received his own novel, *Mort*, in 1987. Piers Anthony's *Incarnations of Immortality* (from 1983) made Death, Time, Fate, War and Nature into offices held in succession by mortals. Roger Zelazny's *Creatures of Light and Darkness* (1969) staged a cosmos administered by Anubis's House of the Dead and Osiris's House of Life. And the Lords of Order and Chaos from Michael Moorcock's multiverse reappear, lightly transposed, among the petitioners of *Season of Mists*. Gaiman's innovation is to refuse every available category at once. The Endless are older than the gods, who petition them and die before them; they are not allegories, since they have apartments, wardrobes, grudges and a family history; and they are not merely offices, since their holders are persons whose temperaments colour what they administer. They are functions with faces.

3.2 A Table of Transcendental Conditions

The proposal of this chapter is that the seven Endless form a table of the conditions of finite experience, a mythological counterpart to the table by which Kant specified what must hold for experience to be possible at all. Each sibling names something without which a conscious, mortal, wanting creature could not have a world.

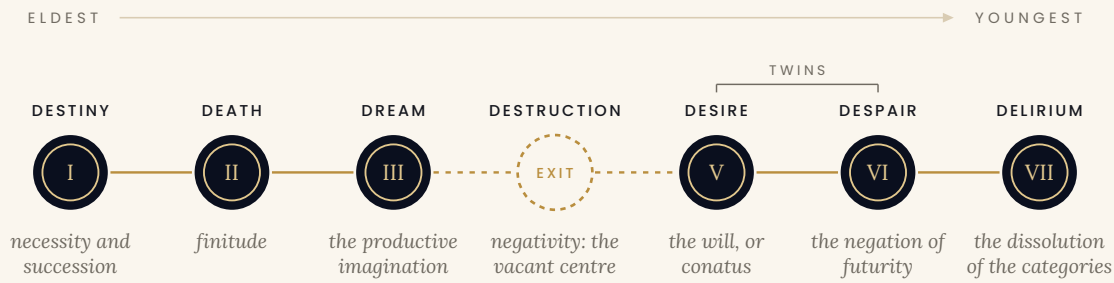


FIGURE 2 *The Endless as a table of the conditions of finite experience, in birth order. The fourth place, Destruction's, is the vacant centre around which the family is organized.*

Destiny, the eldest, is the form of temporal succession and necessity, the principle of Kant's Second Analogy that every alteration follows upon something according to a rule. He carries a book chained to his wrist in which everything is written, and he reads it without writing in it; he is, in Boethius's terms from the fifth book of the *Consolation of Philosophy*, a foreknowledge that does not necessitate. Death is finitude, the condition that Heidegger in *Sein und Zeit* (1927, §§46–53) called Dasein's ownmost possibility, certain yet indefinite, and that gives every life the shape of a whole. Dream is the productive imagination. Kant described the schematism by which concepts find application to intuitions as "eine verborgene Kunst in den Tiefen der menschlichen Seele"—a hidden art in the depths of the human soul (*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*, A141/B180–81)—and Heidegger's *Kant und das Problem der Metaphysik* (1929) argued that this imagination is the common root of sensibility and understanding. Gaiman's Dream occupies the same mediating position, between the necessities of Destiny and Death and the affects embodied by his younger siblings.

Destruction is negativity, the "ungeheure Macht des Negativen," the tremendous power of the negative that Hegel's preface to the *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807) made the energy of thought itself; without him nothing could change, which is why his abdication is the series' philosophical crux. Desire is the will: Spinoza's *conatus*, the striving by which "each thing, as far as it lies in itself, strives to persevere in its being" (*unaquaeque res, quantum in se est, in suo esse perseverare conatur*, *Ethica* III, prop. 6); Schopenhauer's impersonal *Wille*; Lacan's *désir*, which is always the desire of the Other. Gaiman makes Desire androgynous and cruel because the will is indifferent to the persons through whom it strives. Despair, Desire's twin, is the negation of futurity, the "sickness unto death" that Kierkegaard (1849) defined as the self's misrelation to itself—in despair not willing to be oneself, or in despair willing to be oneself. That her

realm looks out through every mirror in the world makes her the patroness of reflexive regard: the look that returns upon the self and finds only its incapacity. Delirium, youngest, who was once Delight, is the condition under which the table itself can fail, the Dionysian dissolution of the *principium individuationis* described in Nietzsche's *Geburt der Tragödie* (1872). Her metamorphosis from Delight to Delirium is the loss of Dionysian joy to Dionysian disintegration, and Todd Klein's lettering, which sets her speech in wobbling, multicoloured balloons, inscribes her ontology on the page.

The logical form of the Endless can be stated more exactly with the help of Frege. In "Funktion und Begriff" (1891), Frege described functions as *ungesättigt*, unsaturated: incomplete in themselves and completed only by an argument. The Endless are unsaturated in exactly this sense. Dream is nothing without a creature that dreams, Death nothing without a creature that lives, Desire nothing without one that wants. Death states the corollary in her own idiom when she explains that her work will be finished only when the last living thing has died, after which she will close up the universe like a café at the end of the night. This is why the Endless are not gods. Gods require belief; the Endless require only the existence of the living. They are not objects of theotrophy but its conditions, the structure within which regard can be given, withdrawn, captured or kept.

3.3 The Vacant Centre

The birth order of the Endless is Destiny, Death, Dream, Destruction, the twins Desire and Despair, and Delirium. Destruction is fourth of seven, the exact centre of the sequence, and he is the one who left. The family is organized around an absence. Its members communicate by grasping one another's sigils in the galleries of their realms, and Destruction's sigil remains in every gallery although he no longer answers. The siblings keep his place: custody of a vacancy.

The structure recalls Derrida's argument in "Structure, Sign, and Play in the Discourse of the Human Sciences" (1966) that the centre of a structure is paradoxically both within it and outside it, the point that organizes the play of the whole while escaping that play itself. Destruction's abdication decentres the Endless. It also makes him the family's only figure of freedom. Albert O. Hirschman's *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970) offers an unexpectedly precise typology of the siblings' responses to their offices. Destruction chooses exit, as Lucifer does in *Season of Mists*; Delirium, clamorous and insistent, embodies voice; Dream embodies loyalty, which, Hirschman observed, delays exit until exit becomes catastrophic. Dream's loyalty to his office postpones his departure until the only exit left is death. The vacant centre is thus the series' normative hinge: the Endless who changed his relation to his function models freedom, the one who could not models tragedy, and the organizing principle of the whole is an empty chair.

3.4 Death, the Gentle Function

Gaiman's Death reverses the iconography of the Reaper. Hesiod's Thanatos has a heart of iron and a spirit pitiless as bronze, and "whomsoever of men he has once seized he holds fast" (*Theogony* 764–66, trans. Evelyn-White, 1914): the classical figure of death is a captor. Gaiman's Death is a young woman in black wearing an ankh, amused, practical and tender, whose closest ancestor is not the Reaper but the courteous gentleman of Emily Dickinson's poem: "Because I could not stop for Death – / He kindly stopped for me –." She does not seize; she receives. In "The Sound of Her Wings" (#8) she makes her rounds while her brother, newly freed and sunk in self-pity, follows, and the issue shows her attending each dying person with a complete and unhurried regard. To an infant who has died in the cot she offers the Stoic consolation, stated in the idiom of a sister, that every life, however brief, is a whole lifetime. Marcus Aurelius had made the same argument in the *Meditations* (II.14): the longest and the shortest life lose the same thing, the present moment, which is all that anyone possesses.

The ethical meaning of the figure is that no one dies unseen. Christian providence guaranteed as much: "Are not two sparrows sold for a farthing? and one of them shall not fall on the ground without your Father" (Matthew 10:29). Gaiman's cosmos lacks a providential eye, as Chapter Ten will argue, and Death inherits its office in miniature. Her regard at the end of each life is total, and it is fiduciary rather than appetitive: she takes nothing for herself. The Epicurean argument that "death, the most awful of evils, is nothing to us, seeing that, when we are, death is not come, and, when death is come, we are not" (Letter to Menoeceus, trans. Hicks, 1925) is thereby given an unexpected supplement: death may be nothing to us, but we are something to Death.

> *Death may be nothing to us, but we are something to Death.*

The legitimacy of her function rests on a kenotic condition. In *Death: The High Cost of Living* (1993) she takes mortal form for one day each century and lives it through to its end, in order to know what the lives she ends are worth. The structure is Pauline: the divine function "made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant" (Philippians 2:7), and it is also Jungian, since *Antwort auf Hiob* argued that divinity must incarnate in order to catch up with the moral consciousness of its creatures. Death has the right to receive lives because she has undergone one. Her custody is authorized by empathy.

The corpus balances this figure with its most sustained argument against the necessity of dying. Hob Gadling, granted in 1389 the privilege of not dying until he chooses, meets Dream once a century and never chooses. Bernard Williams argued in

"The Makropulos Case" (1973) that immortality would inevitably become tedious, and Borges in "The Immortal" (1947) and Simone de Beauvoir in *Tous les hommes sont mortels* (1946) imagined deathless lives emptied of meaning. Hob is a narrative refutation of all three: through poverty, grief and centuries of reinvention his appetite for life renews itself. The same appetite carries him, in the late seventeenth century, into the Atlantic slave trade, which he comes by the series' end to remember with shame: the corpus does not exempt its emblem of vitality from the economy of capture. Martin Hägglund's *This Life* (2019) would reply that Hob's care for his life still presupposes its finitude, since he could lose it by choosing; and those are the precise terms of his gift. Death grants him not immortality but a custody of his own ending. What the corpus honours is not deathlessness but the dignity of the choice.

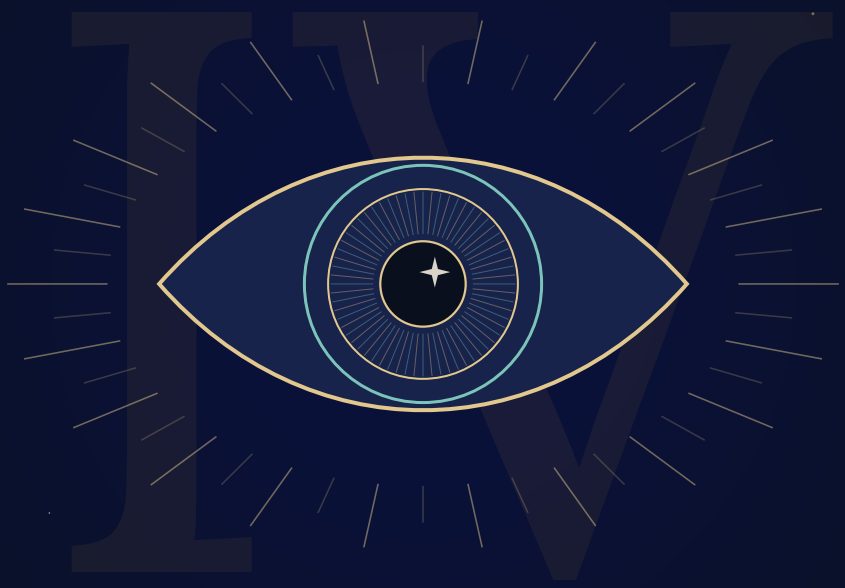
3.5 Destiny and the Garden of Forking Paths

Destiny walks a garden whose paths divide endlessly, a direct homage to Borges's "El jardín de senderos que se bifurcan" (1941), and he reads in his book a story that includes the story in which he appears. The reader of *The Sandman* is therefore in Destiny's position: someone who holds a book in which everything has already happened and who reads it without altering it. The comparison with speculative fiction is instructive. Kurt Vonnegut's Tralfamadorians in *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969) see all moments simultaneously and counsel indifference; Ted Chiang's "Story of Your Life" (1998) imagines a linguist who, having learned to perceive time as the heptapods do, chooses to enact a future she already knows, so that foreknowledge becomes performance rather than resignation. Gaiman's Destiny sits between them. He is blind: necessity, in this cosmos, sees nothing. He reads. The implication, which the theory of custody will develop, is that regard need not be sight. To keep a story one need not look at it; one need only go on reading.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Ocular Economy

From Hoffmann's Eye-Thief to the Buttoned Gaze



The button fills the eye; the hag stone empties a space to see through.

CHAPTER FOUR · THE OCULAR ECONOMY

IF regard is the substance of Gaiman's cosmos, the eye is its currency, and the corpus is saturated with ocular transactions: eyes stolen, eaten, pledged, sewn shut and restored. This chapter argues that these transactions form a single iconographic system whose two poles are the *button*, which fastens and fills the eye, and the *aperture*, which empties a space to see through. The first is the emblem of capture, the second of custody.

4.1 The Eye-Thief and the Return of the Repressed

The name *Sandman* reaches Gaiman through three lineages, and they disagree about eyes. The commercial lineage runs through DC Comics: Wesley Dodds, the gas-masked Golden Age Sandman of 1939 who put criminals to sleep, and the superhero created by Joe Simon and Jack Kirby in 1974. The benign folk lineage runs through Hans Christian Andersen's "Ole Lukøje" (1841), in which the sandman who sprinkles sleep into children's eyes and holds a picture-umbrella over good children shows the boy Hjalmar, on the last night of the week, his brother, who also bears his name, visits each person only once, and carries them away on his horse. Andersen had already made Dream and Death brothers. The malign lineage runs through E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816), whose nurse tells the child Nathanael of a wicked man who throws handfuls of sand into the eyes of children who will not go to bed, *daß sie blutig zum Kopf herausspringen*—so that they spring bleeding from their heads—and carries the eyes to the half-moon to feed his owl-beaked children. Hoffmann's tale proceeds through the barometer-seller Coppola, who hawks *sköne Oke*, pretty eyes, in the form of lenses, and through the automaton Olimpia, whom Nathanael loves through a spyglass, to madness and death.

Freud built his essay "Das Unheimliche" (1919) upon this story, reading the fear of losing one's eyes as a displaced castration anxiety and correcting Ernst Jentsch's earlier account (1906), which had located uncanniness in uncertainty about whether a being is animate. Gaiman's Morpheus inherits Andersen's gentleness and DC's name, and the Hoffmannian eye-thief is expelled from him—only to return inside the series, in accordance with Freud's own law of the return of the repressed. The Corinthian, a nightmare Dream made and lost, wears dark glasses over eye sockets in which small toothed mouths are set, and he eats the eyes of those he kills. He is appetitive regard incarnate: an eye that devours rather than sees. His natural society is the convention of serial killers in *The Doll's House*, a gathering of collectors of human beings. Dream unmakes him for having become a predator, and the significance of the unmaking is completed only in *The Kindly Ones*, where a new Corinthian, remade, serves as a

guardian of the child Daniel. The eye-eater converted into a keeper is the ocular economy's emblem of redemption: appetite redirected, not abolished.

4.2 The Pledged Eye and the Restored Eye

Norse myth supplies the economy's law of exchange. In the *Völuspá* the seeress tells Odin that she knows what he has paid for wisdom: "I know where Othin's eye is hidden, / Deep in the wide-famed well of Mimir; / Mead from the pledge of Othin each morn / Does Mimir drink" (trans. Bellows, 1923). Snorri's *Gylfaginning* confirms that Odin pledged an eye for a drink from the well. Knowledge is bought with sight: the god who sees most sees with one eye. Wednesday, the one-eyed grifter of *American Gods*, carries the bargain into the present, and it is fitting that the most knowing figure in the novel is also its most accomplished deceiver.

A Greek story supplies the complementary law of restoration. Plato's Socrates, in the *Phaedrus* (243a), recalls that the poet Stesichorus was struck blind for slandering Helen, and that, unlike Homer, he understood the cause and composed a recantation: "False is that word of mine—the truth is that thou didst not embark in ships, nor ever go to the walls of Troy; and when he had completed his poem, which is called 'the recantation,' immediately his sight returned to him" (trans. Jowett). Euripides' *Helen* (412 BCE) dramatizes the same revision, in which the Greeks and Trojans fought for a phantom, an *eidolon* shaped from cloud, while the real Helen waited in Egypt. The poet who tells a story unjustly is blinded; the poet who retells it justly sees again. Chapter Seven builds its theory of the palinode on this episode. Here it suffices to note that between Odin and Stesichorus the ocular economy acquires both its price and its remedy: sight can be given up for knowledge, and it can be recovered by a truer story. The tradition of the blind seer—Tiresias, Oedipus, and Gloucester in *King Lear*, who confesses that he "stumbled when I saw" (IV.i.19)—stands behind Gaiman's blind Destiny, whose necessity sees nothing and reads everything.

4.3 The Buttoned Gaze: Coraline

Coraline (2002) is the ocular economy's purest parable. Behind a bricked-up door in her new flat, a bored and under-attended child finds a corridor to a second house in which a second mother, with black buttons for eyes, offers her everything her own distracted parents do not: delicious meals, undivided interest, games, a room full of wonders. The price of staying is that Coraline must allow buttons to be sewn into her own eyes. The offer is capture in its most exact form. Perfect regard is available on condition that one surrender one's own regard; to be looked at completely by the Other Mother is to cease to look. And the chosen instrument is telling. A button is a fastener. The eye, sewn shut with one, becomes a closure, the organ of perception converted into the hardware by which a garment is secured.

The novel's other ocular object is its antithesis. Coraline's elderly neighbours, Miss Spink and Miss Forcible, give her a stone with a hole in it, the hag stone or adder stone

of British folklore through which one could see fairies and against which witches had no power. Through it Coraline sees the souls of the Other Mother's earlier victims, the ghost children behind the mirror, as glowing points she can recover. The opposition could not be sharper. The button fills the eye; the hag stone empties a space to see through. Capture occludes by plenitude; custody sees through an aperture. The hollow, as Chapter Six will argue, is the geometry of fiduciary regard.

> *Capture occludes by plenitude; custody sees through an aperture.*

The ghost children themselves have forgotten their names, and they warn Coraline in the manner of Keats's knight-at-arms: "I saw pale kings and princes too, / Pale warriors, death-pale were they all; / They cried—'La Belle Dame sans Merci / Thee hath in thrall!'" (1819). Gaiman's ghosts call the Other Mother "the beldam," a word that descends from the Middle English *beldame*, grandmother, before it hardened into "hag," and that sounds, as the English Romantics heard it, like the *belle dame* herself. The novel places its heroine in Keats's position, warned by the pale ranks of the previously captured. Only the nameless cat, who moves freely between the two houses and regards names as a necessity only for those who do not know who they are, is immune; the creature that has no name cannot have it stolen.

The psychoanalytic criticism of the novel supports the reading. Bruno Bettelheim's *The Uses of Enchantment* (1976) argued that fairy tales split the mother into good and wicked figures so that the child can hate the latter without losing the former; *Coraline* literalizes the split in two houses. D. W. Winnicott's concept of the "good-enough mother," who fails the infant gradually and thereby permits its independence, illuminates the novel's surprising preference for the busy, imperfect real mother over the flawless attentiveness of her double: Winnicott's point was precisely that perfect maternal adaptation is pathogenic. Lacan's formula that desire is the desire of the Other finds a literal embodiment in a creature named the Other Mother who asks the child to become the object of her want; and Freud's *unheimlich* is realized architecturally, since the other house is the *Heim* duplicated and made strange. David Rudd's "An Eye for an I" (2008) reads the novel's central wager as the securing of identity through the refusal of the buttons; Elizabeth Parsons, Naarah Sawers and Kate McInally (2008) observe that the novel's sympathies rest with the working mother and question whether its resolution is liberating or merely postfeminist. The present reading adds that the choice Coraline makes is between two economies of regard, and that she chooses the one in which she is imperfectly seen but retains the power to see. She ends the novel by luring the Other Mother's severed, grasping hand into an old well and sealing it: the appetitive hand, like the pledged eye of Odin, is buried in a well.

4.4 Gaze Theory and a Periodization of Capture

Twentieth-century theory supplies the ocular economy with its concepts. Sartre's *regard* in *L'Être et le néant* (1943) is the look that objectifies, catching the voyeur at the keyhole in shame. Lacan's *Seminar* XI (1964) relocated the gaze to the side of the object: the picture, he argued, looks at me. Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* (1975) described the panopticon, which disciplines by making its subjects permanently visible to an unseen watcher. Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) named the male gaze that converts women into spectacle; "Calliope" carries that gaze past spectacle into possession, since its novelist holds the Muse as property and rapes her as a means of production. Gaiman's corpus absorbs each concept and binds it to a figure: Despair, who watches through every mirror, embodies the Sartrean look turned upon oneself; the Corinthian, Lacan's devouring gaze; the spooks of *American Gods*, the panoptic watcher; Richard Madoc, the captor of the Muse.

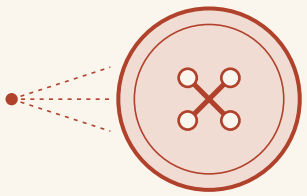
These figures also permit a periodization. The corpus stages capture in three historical registers. The first is occult: Roderick Burgess's glass sphere of 1916, the magus attempting to seize finitude and netting only its dream. The second is broadcast: the seventy-two years of Dream's captivity, from 1916 to 1988, coincide almost exactly with the span of what Hortense Powdermaker called, in 1950, Hollywood's "dream factory," and of what Horkheimer and Adorno in *Dialektik der Aufklärung* (1944/47) called the culture industry, the apparatus that manufactured the dream-life of mass societies. The premise of *The Sandman* can be read as an allegory of that century: while the lord of dreams sat in a cellar, human beings dreamt what industry supplied. The third register is networked: Dream escapes on the eve of the World Wide Web, and in 2001 *American Gods* finds capture relocated to the Technical Boy. Jonathan Crary's *Suspensions of Perception* (1999) traced the management of attention as the defining problem of modernity since the late nineteenth century, and his 24/7 (2013) identified sleep as the last interval not yet colonized; *The Sandman* is, among other things, a defence of that interval. Two speculative fictions complete the picture. Philip K. Dick's Palmer Eldritch, in *The Three Stigmata of Palmer Eldritch* (1965), bears artificial eyes among his stigmata and infects his consumers' perception with his own; China Miéville's slake-moths in *Perdido Street Station* (2000) feed on the minds and dreams of sentient beings, paralyse their prey with the patterns on their wings, and can be confronted only in mirrors, as Perseus confronted Medusa. Both are allegories of the capture of attention, and both confirm that the ocular economy is not Gaiman's private obsession but a structure the speculative imagination of his period discovered repeatedly.

The corpus, however, does not end in diagnosis. Against the button it sets the aperture; against the eye that eats, the eye that keeps watch. Death's regard at the end of each life, the hag stone's hollow, the Zorya sisters of *American Gods* who keep perpetual watch over something chained in the stars lest it escape and end the world, and blind Destiny, who reads without seeing, together describe an alternative optics.

Custody does not require the dominion of sight. It requires only that someone go on watching, and that the watching serve the watched.

THE BUTTON

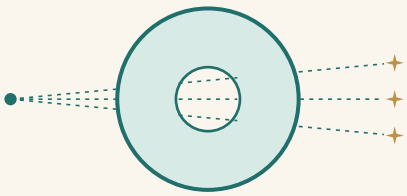
capture: the eye fastened



Burgess's glass sphere · the Corinthian · the Other Mother · Bilquis · Media · the Technical Boy · the spooks

THE APERTURE

custody: the eye kept open



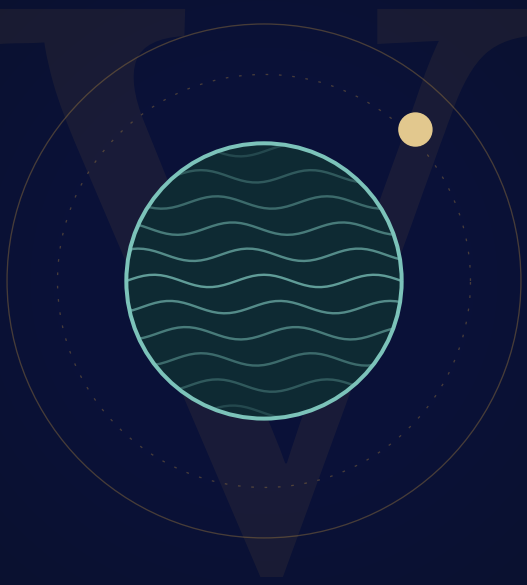
Death's regard · the hag stone · the Zorya's watch · blind Destiny · the Hempstocks · Mr. Ibis's pen

FIGURE 3 *The two poles of the ocular economy: the button, which fastens and fills the eye, and the aperture, which empties a space to see through.*

CHAPTER FIVE

Custodial Enchantment

London Below, the Graveyard, and the Ocean in the Duck Pond



Gaiman answers with a vessel: an ocean held in a duck pond, a totality kept in a small place by those who care.

CHAPTER FIVE · CUSTODIAL ENCHANTMENT

GAIMAN'S answer to the disenchantment of the world is neither a return to belief nor an acceptance of its loss but a third thing, which this thesis names *custodial enchantment*: enchantment understood as a practice of care for what is precarious, unseen or forgotten, rather than as credence in the supernatural. This chapter locates the concept in its philosophical context and reads its three great exemplary spaces—London Below, the graveyard of *The Graveyard Book*, and the Hempstock farm—as institutions of custody.

5.1 Disenchantment and Its Discontents

Max Weber's lecture "Wissenschaft als Beruf" (delivered 1917, published 1919) named the condition that modern fantasy exists to contest: "Das Schicksal unserer Zeit, mit der ihr eigenen Rationalisierung und Intellektualisierung, vor allem: Entzauberung der Welt"—the fate of our time, with its rationalization and intellectualization, is above all the disenchantment of the world. Charles Taylor's *A Secular Age* (2007) redescribed the transition as the replacement of a "porous" self, open to spirits and forces, by a "buffered" self enclosed in an immanent frame; Jason Josephson-Storm's *The Myth of Disenchantment* (2017) argued that the transition never fully occurred; and Jane Bennett's *The Enchantment of Modern Life* (2001) proposed that moments of enchantment within modernity are an ethical resource, fostering the generosity on which ethical life depends. Gaiman's protagonists are porous selves in a buffered world, and his fiction corroborates Josephson-Storm: enchantment survives in the cracks, the cellars and the roadside attractions. But its moral significance is Bennett's. Wonder, in Gaiman, is valuable not because it is true but because it trains attention on what is fading.

The fantasy theorists who preceded him had already bound enchantment to sight and to care. Tolkien's "On Fairy-Stories" (lecture 1939, published 1947) described *Recovery* as the regaining of a clear view, a cleansing of perception from the blur of possessive familiarity—an ocular virtue that belongs with the aperture of the previous chapter. G. K. Chesterton's *Orthodoxy* (1908) found in fairy tales "the Doctrine of Conditional Joy," by which every happiness in elfland hangs upon an arbitrary condition—a word unspoken, a box unopened—and inferred from the world's tireless repetitions that God may possess "the eternal appetite of infancy; for we have sinned and grown old, and our Father is younger than we." Chesterton's *Tremendous Trifles* (1909) supplied the passage that Gaiman condensed into the epigraph of *Coraline*: "Fairy tales do not give the child his first idea of bogey. What fairy tales give the child is his first clear idea of the possible defeat of bogey." Gaiman's paraphrase is more concise than its source, and it now circulates more widely than the original; the

epigraph is itself an instance of the metamorphic survival that Chapter Two described. Chesterton also appears in the corpus in person, so to speak. In *The Doll's House*, Fiddler's Green, a place in the Dreaming, takes human form as Gilbert, drawn in Chesterton's likeness, to shelter the endangered Rose Walker. The author of *Orthodoxy* becomes, literally, a refuge.

5.2 London Below: Transcendental Homelessness Literalized

Neverwhere (1996) begins with an act of regard. Richard Mayhew, a young securities analyst on his way to an important dinner, stops for a bleeding girl on a pavement whom everyone else steps around. The girl is Door, of the House of Arch, whose family can open anything; and Richard's kindness costs him his existence. In London Above his flat is let to strangers, his fiancée forgets him, his desk is removed, and taxis do not stop. He has fallen through the cracks, and the novel's governing parable follows: in a city organized by the refusal to see, attending to the unseen makes one unseen. The structure inverts the parable of the Good Samaritan (Luke 10:30–37), in which the priest and the Levite "passed by on the other side"; in Gaiman's London the Samaritan is punished by being made to join the man in the ditch.

The world Richard falls into is a literalization of Georg Lukács's definition of the novel, in *Die Theorie des Romans* (1916), as the form of *transzendentale Obdachlosigkeit*—transcendental homelessness, the condition of a world abandoned by God. London Below is populated by the literally homeless, and it is organized by the literalization of names. Earl's Court is the court of an actual earl, held in a carriage of the Underground; Knightsbridge becomes Night's Bridge, where the darkness takes those who cross; Blackfriars houses black friars, Hammersmith a smith, Shepherd's Bush a flock of terrifying shepherds; the Angel, Islington is an angel. The method is Cratylist. In Plato's *Cratylus*, Socrates tests whether names belong to things by nature (φύσει) or by convention (νόμῳ); Gaiman builds a city in which convention has hardened back into nature, and every name is its referent. Walter Benjamin's "Über Sprache überhaupt und über die Sprache des Menschen" (1916) supplies the pathos of this procedure: fallen human language, Benjamin argued, *overnames* things, and the mute sorrow of nature is the sorrow of being overnamed. London Below is the city of the overnamed, where the names have taken on bodies and the bodies are the names' forgotten debts.

The novel's sociology descends from the Victorian investigation of the street poor. Its protagonist's surname summons Henry Mayhew, whose *London Labour and the London Poor* (1851) catalogued the city's mudlarks, crossing-sweepers and "toshers," the sewer-hunters who scavenged beneath the streets; London Below, with its rat-speakers and sewer-folk, is Mayhew's underclass rendered as a mythic polity. Behind it stand Dickens's river-dredgers in *Our Mutual Friend* (1864–65) and Thomas De Quincey's *Confessions of an English Opium-Eater* (1821), whose most haunting episode is the loss of Ann, the Oxford Street girl who vanished into the crowds and whom De Quincey searched for in vain—a girl who fell through the cracks. Theory

supplies the politics. Michel de Certeau's "Walking in the City" (*L'Invention du quotidien*, 1980) distinguished the *strategies* of those who survey the city from above from the *tactics* of those who improvise within it; the Floating Market of London Below, convened in a different place each time—a department store after closing, a warship on the Thames—is tactical space in its purest form. Jacques Rancière's account of politics as the redistribution of the sensible, a reconfiguration of who can be seen and heard on behalf of "the part of those who have no part" (*La Mésentente*, 1995; *Le Partage du sensible*, 2000), describes what the novel's fantasy performs. Ralph Ellison's narrator in *Invisible Man* (1952), invisible because others refuse to see him, and Axel Honneth's essay on invisibility as a failure of recognition (2001), name the social fact that London Below literalizes; China Miéville's *The City & the City* (2009) would later make "unseeing" a civic discipline enforced by a secret power.

Two figures in *Neverwhere* specify the custodial ethic. The Marquis de Carabas takes his name from Perrault's "Le Maître chat ou le Chat botté" (1697), in which the title is a fiction invented by a cat to ennoble a penniless miller's son: his very nobility is a con. Yet the Marquis keeps his life in a small silver box entrusted to Old Bailey, and when Croup and Vandemar kill him the box restores him. Frazer devoted chapters of *The Golden Bough* to the folk-motif of the external soul—the ogre Koshchei the Deathless, whose death lies hidden in a needle within an egg within a duck—in which a life is kept elsewhere so that it cannot be taken. Gaiman converts the motif from a strategy of invulnerability into an act of trust: the external soul becomes a deposit held by a friend. Door, for her part, is the threshold personified, the figure of Arnold van Gennep's *Les Rites de passage* (1909) and Victor Turner's liminality, whose gift is not to hold but to let through. And the novel refuses the Campbellian return. Joseph Campbell's hero comes back as "Master of the Two Worlds"; Richard comes back to London Above, finds his restored life hollow, and walks through a door in a wall into the world of the unseen. The hero's boon is not carried home but renounced for the sake of those without one. Miéville's *Un Lun Dun* (2007) would later satirize the chosen hero; Richard was never chosen. He was merely the one person who looked down.

5.3 The Graveyard: Heterotopia and Polder

The Graveyard Book (2008), the first book to receive both the Newbery and the Carnegie Medals, rewrites Kipling's *Jungle Book* with the dead in place of the wolves. A toddler who escapes the man who murdered his family is taken in by the ghosts of a hillside cemetery, granted the Freedom of the Graveyard, named Nobody Owens, and raised by the Owenses, by a guardian named Silas who belongs neither to the living nor to the dead, and by Miss Lupescu, a Hound of God. Foucault's lecture "Des espaces autres" (1967, published 1984) made the cemetery its principal example of a *heterotopia*, a real place that contains, contests and inverts the other sites of a culture; Clute's *polder* names an enclave in which an older reality is kept against the encroachments of a thinning world. The graveyard is both, and it is also a civic body. The Freedom of the Graveyard, modelled on the honorary freedom of a city, makes custody a form of citizenship, and the dead's reception of a living child realizes what Derrida in *De l'hospitalité* (1997) called unconditional hospitality: the welcome extended to the stranger before any question of his name.

Bod's curriculum is a pedagogy of the unseen: Fading, Dreamwalking, Haunting. Plato described education in the *Republic* (VII, 518c–d) not as putting sight into blind eyes but as turning, *periagōgē*, the soul's eye toward what it had not faced; Bod's education turns his eyes toward two worlds at once. The novel's custodians are measured against a counterfeit. Deep in a barrow beneath the hill sits the Sleer, an ancient serpentine guardian that has kept a treasure for a master long gone and waits, forever, for his return. The Sleer is custody without *telos*, a keeping that has forgotten release; it descends from the dragon that the *Beowulf* poet calls *hordweard*, hoard-ward, the guardian who has become the possessor, whom Tolkien's "Beowulf: The Monsters and the Critics" (1936) read as malice and greed in bodily form. This thesis accordingly formulates the *Sleer corollary*: custody that forgets its end in release degenerates into capture. The novel converts the hoard. Bod takes a brooch from the Sleer's barrow to buy a headstone for Liza Hempstock, a young woman whom her town drowned and then burned as a witch, and buried without a marker in unconsecrated ground—treasure withdrawn from a keeping that served no one and spent on remembering someone the world forgot. And in the chapter titled "Danse Macabre," the living and the dead dance together on the one night when the winter flowers bloom, as in the Totentanz of Holbein's woodcuts (1538), after which the living forget that they have danced.

The ending is the anti-Sleer. As Bod grows, he loses the ability to see the dead, and his guardians send him out with a passport and money into the living world, as Mowgli is sent from the jungle in Kipling's "The Spring Running" (1895). The graveyard keeps him in order to let him go. That is the difference between a polder and a hoard.

> *The graveyard keeps him in order to let him go. That is the difference between a polder and a hoard.*

5.4 The Ocean in the Duck Pond

The Ocean at the End of the Lane (2013) is the corpus's most concentrated meditation on custody, and its central image is an infinite held in a small vessel. A middle-aged man, back in Sussex for a funeral, drives to the farm at the end of the lane where he once knew a girl named Lettie Hempstock, sits beside the duck pond she called her ocean, and remembers what happened when he was seven: a lodger's suicide in the family car after ruinous gambling losses, the arrival of a being from outside that took the form of a housekeeper called Ursula Monkton and gave people money, her seduction of his father, the night the father, enraged, held him under the bathwater and nearly drowned him, and the coming of the hunger birds, scavengers of the universe who remove what does not belong and who wanted the passage that remained in the boy's heart.

The Hempstocks—Lettie, who has been eleven for a very long time; her mother Ginnie; and Old Mrs Hempstock, who claims to remember the universe's beginning—are Robert Graves's triple goddess of *The White Goddess* (1948), maiden, mother and crone, and they are also the Moirai and the Norns. Old Mrs Hempstock repairs the damage done to the boy's family by cutting pieces out of the night and stitching the fabric back together, editing what the family will remember. The act deserves to be set beside the Other Mother's. Both are seamstresses; both sew what they touch; the one sews buttons into a child's eyes to keep him, the other sews the world so that a child may go on. The craft is identical. The telos is opposite.

When Lettie takes the boy into her ocean he knows everything, and would dissolve into that knowing if he stayed; when she is torn by the hunger birds in his defence, the ocean takes her back to heal. Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) offers the decisive comparison: Lem's planetary ocean reads the memories of the scientists who orbit it and returns them as bodies, the "visitors" who haunt the station—memory restored as uncanny capture. Gaiman's ocean receives memory and keeps it. The deeper comparison is Platonic. At the end of the *Republic* the souls awaiting rebirth camp by "the river of Unmindfulness, whose water no vessel can hold" (X, 621a, trans. Jowett), and drink from it, and forget. The river's Greek name is *Amelēs*, from *a-* and *melē*: without care. For Plato, forgetting is carelessness, and no vessel can contain it. Gaiman answers with a vessel: an ocean held in a duck pond, a totality kept in a small place by those who care. The Hempstock farm is the institution of what Paul Ricoeur, in *La*

Mémoire, l'histoire, l'oubli (2000), called *l'oubli de réserve*—a forgetting held in reserve, in which memory is not effaced but kept latent and retrievable. The frame reveals that the man has returned to the pond several times over the years, remembered each time, and forgotten again on leaving. His memory is not destroyed. It is held in trust.

The novel stands in a Romantic lineage of adult exile from childhood knowledge. Wordsworth's "Ode: Intimations of Immortality" (1807) declared that "Our birth is but a sleep and a forgetting" and that "Shades of the prison-house begin to close / Upon the growing Boy"; Lovecraft's "The Silver Key" (1929) exiled Randolph Carter from the land of dreams on his thirtieth birthday; Proust's madeleine (1913) restored a lost world through involuntary memory, as the pond restores Gaiman's narrator. And it stands in a balladic lineage of custody through transformation. In "Tam Lin" (Child 39), Janet wins her lover back from the Queen of Fairies by holding him while he is changed into adder, bear, lion and burning brand, as he has instructed her: "hold me fast, and fear me not." Diana Wynne Jones rewrote the ballad as *Fire and Hemlock* (1985). *The Ocean at the End of the Lane* is a Tam Lin that fails: Lettie tells the boy not to let go of her hand, he lets go when he is startled, and the thing from outside gets in through his foot. The redemption of the failure is that she then holds him.

The final scene settles the ethic. The Hempstocks consider whether the man's life has been worth Lettie's sacrifice, and Old Mrs Hempstock refuses the question: one does not, she says in effect, pass or fail at being a person. Against every meritocratic theodicy—including, as Chapter Seven shows, the one C. S. Lewis applied to Susan Pevensie—custody is not conditional on the worth of what is kept. Kazuo Ishiguro's *The Buried Giant* (2015), in which a dragon's breath of forgetting preserves a fragile peace that remembering will destroy, frames the alternative starkly: Lethe or Mnemosyne, amnesia or memory. Gaiman proposes a third term between them, a *fiduciary memory* held elsewhere, by others, for the one who cannot yet bear it.

CHAPTER SIX

The Nobody

Negative Capability and the Apophatic Subject



Names capture; namelessness protects; and a name kept by another, remembered in trust, sets free.

CHAPTER SIX · THE NOBODY

THE ideal regarder of Gaiman's economy is a Nobody: a subject defined by emptiness, receptivity and the absence of appetite, who can keep because he does not seek to possess. This chapter traces the figure to Keats and Homer, reinterprets the much-criticized passivity of Gaiman's protagonists as an ascesis of attention in Simone Weil's sense, and then turns the thesis's own criterion against the corpus, which distributes the labour of custody along lines of gender that its ethic cannot justify.

6.1 The Chameleon Poet

Keats is the unacknowledged father of Gaiman's aesthetics, and his presence in the corpus is literal as well as structural. *Season of Mists* takes its title from the first line of "To Autumn" ("Season of mists and mellow fruitfulness"); *Coraline* borrows the scene of "La Belle Dame sans Merci"; and Dream's melancholy rehearses the confession of the "Ode to a Nightingale": "for many a time / I have been half in love with easeful Death." More fundamentally, two sentences from Keats's letters define the corpus's epistemic and subjective ideals. To his brothers in December 1817 Keats described *Negative Capability*, "that is when man is capable of being in uncertainties, Mysteries, doubts, without any irritable reaching after fact & reason." To Richard Woodhouse in October 1818 he described the poetical character: "A Poet is the most unpoetical of any thing in existence; because he has no Identity—he is continually in for—and filling some other Body."

Negative capability is the epistemic virtue of custody. Gaiman withholds explanation with a consistency that readers sometimes mistake for evasiveness: Silas's nature is never named; the Hempstocks' origin is never disclosed; the reason Delight became Delirium is never given; the "ineffable plan" of *Good Omens* is, by definition, ineffable. The withholding is principled. The "irritable reaching after fact & reason" is appetitive regard applied to meaning, the attempt to capture a mystery by resolving it. Custody keeps what it does not understand, and the fiction trains its reader to do the same. The poet without identity, in turn, is the prototype of the Gaimanian protagonist, who is repeatedly an empty vessel through which the stories of others pass.

6.2 Outis: A Genealogy of the Nobody

The first Nobody in Western literature is Odysseus in the cave of Polyphemus. Asked his name by the Cyclops, he answers: "Noman is my name, and Noman they call me, my father and my mother and all my fellows" (*Odyssey* IX.366–67, trans. Butcher and Lang, 1879). The episode is, in retrospect, the founding scene of the ocular economy: a one-eyed giant who devours men is blinded by a man who calls himself no one. Appetitive regard, monocular and literal in its hunger, is defeated by an absence of identity—and Odysseus's one lapse, shouting his true name from the departing ship, delivers him to Poseidon's curse. Anonymity protects; the name exposes.

> *Anonymity protects; the name exposes.*

Gaiman's protagonists form a gallery of Nobodies. Bod Owens is named Nobody because, as the dead observe, he looks like nobody but himself. Shadow Moon bears the name of something that has no body. Richard Mayhew is unmade into no one by the city that refuses to see him. The narrator of *The Ocean at the End of the Lane* is never named at all. Tristran Thorn, half of Faerie and half of Wall, belongs wholly to neither; Fat Charlie Nancy labours under a name that is someone else's joke. Borges's Shakespeare, who was no one, and Fernando Pessoa, who dispersed himself into the heteronyms Caeiro, Reis and Campos, are the literary kin of this gallery. At the opposite pole stands Dream, the most overnamed figure in the corpus—Morpheus, Oneiros, Kai'ckul, Lord Shaper, the Sandman—whose sorrow, in the terms of Benjamin's essay on language, is the sorrow of the overnamed; and beside him the nameless cat of *Coraline*, who is serene because no one owns his name.

The corpus thus proposes an onomastic ethic that its speculative contemporaries share. In Genesis 2:19–20 Adam names the animals, and naming is dominion. Ursula K. Le Guin's Earthsea, from "The Rule of Names" (1964) and *A Wizard of Earthsea* (1968), makes knowledge of a true name the ground of magical power over its bearer; her late parable "She Unnames Them" (1985) has Eve return the names to Adam and release the animals from the relation of mastery the names encoded. Hayao Miyazaki's *Spirited Away* (2001) turns the ethic into plot: the witch Yubaba binds her servants by taking their names, the dragon-boy Haku has forgotten that he is the spirit of the Kohaku River, and Chihiro frees him by remembering his name for him. Gaiman's corpus articulates the same three terms. Names capture; namelessness protects; and a name *kept by another*, remembered in trust, sets free.

6.3 Attention as Passion: Shadow and Simone Weil

Readers of *American Gods* have often complained that Shadow is passive: he is acted upon, he waits, he watches, he rarely initiates. The complaint is accurate and the judgement mistaken. Shadow's passivity is an ascesis of attention in precisely Simone Weil's sense. In "Reflections on the Right Use of School Studies with a View to the Love of God" (1942), Weil described attention as a suspension of thought that leaves the mind detached, empty and ready to be penetrated by its object; her *Attente de Dieu* made waiting (*attente*) the form of the soul's openness, and *La Pesanteur et la grâce* (1947) called for a *décréation* of the self so that the real might be. Iris Murdoch translated the idea into moral philosophy as *unselfing*, illustrated by the hovering kestrel whose sudden sight dissolves the brooding ego. Meister Eckhart's sermon on the poor in spirit—the poor man who wants nothing, knows nothing and has nothing—and his doctrine of *Gelassenheit* stand behind both, as does Heidegger's later opposition between the *Gestell*, the enframing that turns every being into standing-reserve ("Die Frage nach der Technik," 1954), and the *Schonen*, the sparing that leaves a thing in its own essence, which he made the meaning of dwelling ("Bauen Wohnen Denken," 1951). The *Gestell* is capture as a technological epoch; the *Schonen* is custody.

Shadow's great act is a Passion in the etymological sense, since *passivity* and *passion* both descend from *patior*, to undergo. He hangs nine days on the World Tree, tended by three women who are the Norns, re-enacting the self-sacrifice of the *Hávamál*; he dies; in the hall of the dead Anubis weighs his heart; and, offered a choice of destinations, he chooses nothing, and receives it. No figure in modern fantasy is more rigorously apophatic. It is Easter, the vernal goddess, who brings him back—a resurrection the novel does not trouble to make solemn—and only then can he perform the act that ends the war. Because he alone has attended without appetite, he alone sees the con, and he unmakes it by describing it.

The corpus confirms that invisibility is the condition of such regard. In "August" (*Sandman* #30), the emperor Augustus spends one day each year disguised as a beggar, because the gods do not see beggars, and uses the day to plan in secret the limits of the empire the gods would have him expand, and to tell the one companion with him how Julius Caesar, now a god of the state, raped him when he was a boy. Destruction, having left his realm, lives anonymously as a failed painter on an island. The Nobody attends because he is unattended. In Rancière's political idiom, he is the part of those who have no part—which is why the Nobody is not only the corpus's aesthetic and ethical ideal but its political subject.

6.4 The Gendered Labour of Custody: A Critique

The thesis's own criterion now requires a critique. The Nobodies of the corpus are overwhelmingly male—Shadow, Richard, Bod, Tristran, Fat Charlie, the narrator of *Ocean*—and the custodians who hold them are overwhelmingly female. Lettie Hempstock is torn apart shielding the boy she has promised to protect; her mother and grandmother edit the world on his behalf; Door leads Richard through London Below, and the huntress Hunter dies there; Laura Moon, dead, kills for her living husband; the Zorya keep their watch; four old women keep Anansi's memory; Mrs Owens adopts the child; Death receives everyone. The pattern is not incidental. Women hold; men are held.

Feminist care ethics supplies the terms in which to judge this. Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) and Nel Noddings's *Caring* (1984) described an ethic of care long associated with women; Joan Tronto's *Moral Boundaries* (1993) insisted that care is a political question about who performs care work and who is excused from it; Eva Feder Kittay's *Love's Labor* (1999) analysed the invisible "dependency work" on which every autonomous subject relies; and Silvia Federici's *Wages against Housework* (1975) had already named the unpaid reproductive labour underwriting the visible economy. Gaiman's custodial ethic is a care ethic, and in its distribution of labour it reproduces the gendered division that these theorists exposed. By the thesis's own measure, custody that consumes the keeper for the sake of the kept edges toward the capture of the keeper. Lettie's sacrifice is the corpus's most moving act and its most troubling.

The corpus contains its own counter-examples, and they matter. Coraline is a girl who saves herself and then becomes the custodian of the ghost children. Death is a female custodian who is sovereign rather than self-sacrificing. The queen of *The Sleeper and the Spindle* (2013) rides out to wake a cursed kingdom, discovers that the sleeping beauty is a crone feeding on the youth of the sleepers, and at the end declines the marriage awaiting her. The most radical custodial act in the corpus belongs to *A Game of You* (1991–92). Wanda, a trans woman, is refused recognition by the moon-magic invoked by the witch Thessaly and dies in a storm; her family buries her as a man, under her deadname; her friend Barbie crosses out the name on the headstone and writes *Wanda* in lipstick; and Death appears to Barbie in a dream accompanied by Wanda as herself. The arc has been read both as a pioneering act of recognition, contemporary with Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990) and Paul Ricoeur's theory of narrative identity in *Soi-même comme un autre* (1990), and as a failure, since it kills its trans character and grants cosmic magic the power to misgender her. Both readings stand. What the custodial reading adds is that the arc's decisive gesture is performed by one woman on behalf of another, against a family and a cosmos that refuse to keep her name, and that Death's regard at the end ratifies the name the world denied. A custodial poetics fully adequate to its principles would generalize that gesture and redistribute the labour the rest of the corpus assigns.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Palinodic Imperative

Retelling as the Restoration of Sight



In Gaiman's economy, no story is original property. Every story is a deposit.

CHAPTER SEVEN · THE PALINODIC IMPERATIVE

GAIMAN'S revisionist retellings are best understood not as parody, pastiche or deconstruction but as *palinodes*: recantations that restore sight to figures whom an earlier story blinded. This chapter reconstructs the palinode as a form, reads the principal retellings in its light, and identifies the dialectic that shadows every recantation, since a story that restores one figure's sight may take another's.

7.1 The Palinode as Form

The form has a mythical founder and a philosophical theorist. The founder is Stesichorus, blinded for slandering Helen and healed on completing his recantation, as recounted in Chapter Four. The theorist is Plato, whose *Phaedrus* is itself structured as a palinode: Socrates delivers a speech against love with his head covered for shame, is checked by his *daimonion*, and uncovers his head to deliver a second speech recanting the first, in praise of divine madness. Among the madnesses he praises is that of the Muses, without which, he insists, no one enters the temple of poetry: "he who, having no touch of the Muses' madness in his soul, comes to the door and thinks that he will get into the temple by the help of art—he, I say, and his poetry are not admitted" (245a, trans. Jowett). The passage is the exact inverse of "Calliope," whose novelist, lacking the madness, imprisons the Muse in order to force his way into the temple. Madoc's crime is the crime of art without inspiration, and Dream's punishment—an unstoppable flood of ideas—is Platonic madness administered as penalty.

The twentieth century's greatest palinode is C. S. Lewis's *Till We Have Faces* (1956), which retells the story of Cupid and Psyche from Apuleius's *Metamorphoses* through the eyes of Psyche's jealous elder sister, Orual. Its first part is Orual's complaint against the gods; its second is her recantation of the complaint. Gaiman's palinodes differ from Lewis's in one decisive respect: they recant the *story*, not the *complaint*. The retelling does not repent of its grievance against the tale; it repents on behalf of the tale, restoring to its blinded figures the regard that the canonical version withheld. This is the *palinodic imperative*: the ethical obligation, internal to the corpus, to retell a story in such a way that those it has made invisible are seen.

7.2 The Palinodes

"Snow, Glass, Apples" (1994) is narrated by the Queen of "Sneewittchen," awaiting execution. In her account, the child with skin white as snow and lips red as blood is a vampiric creature who fed upon her own father, the king, until he died; the prince who finds her in a glass coffin is a necrophile, drawn to her because she seems dead; and the Queen's every act was an attempt to protect a kingdom. In the Grimms' final version (*Kinder- und Hausmärchen* 53, 1857) the stepmother is made to dance in red-hot iron shoes until she falls dead; Gaiman's Queen is condemned to be burned alive by the prince and his bride. The story belongs to a critical and creative movement it did not begin. Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) had read the magic mirror as the voice of the absent king, the patriarchal judgement by which one woman is measured against another; Angela Carter's *The Bloody Chamber* (1979), including the brief, terrible "The Snow Child," had rewritten the fairy tale from inside its sexual politics; and Marina Warner's *From the Beast to the Blonde* (1994) and Jack Zipes's studies historicized the tales as instruments of social formation. Gaiman's contribution is the Stesichorean structure: a narrator long blinded by her role as villain is given the eyes of the story.

The Sleeper and the Spindle (2013) braids "Snow White" with "Sleeping Beauty." A young queen, on the eve of her wedding, rides out with three dwarfs to halt a sleeping sickness spreading from a neighbouring kingdom, discovers that the beauty asleep in the tower is a crone who has stolen the youth of the girl and feeds upon the sleep of the realm, kisses the sleeper awake, and at the end declines the marriage that awaits her. The palinode is directed against the whole lineage of the tale, including its darkest version, Giambattista Basile's "Sole, Luna e Talia" (1634), in which a king who finds Talia asleep rapes her, and she gives birth to twins without waking. In Gaiman the kiss wakes a predator, sleep is a resource harvested by a captor, and the heroine's freedom consists in refusing the ending the story had prepared for her. The tale is also an explicit return to the premise of *The Sandman*, in which the capture of a sleeper causes the world to sicken; *The Sleeper and the Spindle* is a palinode to Gaiman's own myth, told this time from the side of the one who cures rather than the one who suffers.

"The Problem of Susan" (2004) is the most pointed palinode in the corpus. In *The Last Battle* (1956) Lewis admits Susan Pevensie's siblings to Aslan's country after their deaths in a railway accident, while Susan, grown absorbed in the adolescent attractions of fashion and invitations, is no longer considered a friend of Narnia and is left behind. Philip Pullman's essay "The Dark Side of Narnia" (1998) condemned the exclusion as a punishment of female sexuality. Gaiman's story imagines an elderly professor of children's literature, Susan in all but name, who as a girl had to identify the bodies of her family after the crash, and it confronts the theology that made her grief invisible. Its closing dream sequence, deliberately transgressive, stages a sexual encounter between the White Witch and Aslan, exposing the sexuality that the allegory repressed even as it condemned Susan for hers. The story is the corpus's

sharpest statement against salvation by exclusion, and it states the same ethic as the Hempstocks' refusal to grade a life: no one fails at being a person, and the one left behind is the one most in need of keeping.

"A Study in Emerald" (2003), which received the Hugo Award for Best Short Story, recants two canons at once. In a Victorian England ruled for centuries by Lovecraft's Great Old Ones, with an Old One on the throne, a consulting detective and his military companion, recently returned from Afghanistan, pursue a pair of revolutionaries—"Restorationists" who wish to return the world to human rule. Only gradually does the reader understand that the detective is Moriarty, the narrator Moran, and the revolutionaries Holmes and Watson. The villains of the palinode are the heroes of the canon, and the monsters of cosmic horror are the monarchy. The story participates in a wider recantation of Lovecraft, whose cosmic horror is bound up with an explicit racism and a horror of immigrants: Victor LaValle's *The Ballad of Black Tom* (2016) rewrote "The Horror at Red Hook" (1925) from the perspective of the Black Harlem it had demonized, and Matt Ruff's *Lovecraft Country* (2016) turned the Mythos against Jim Crow. Its ancestor is Jean Rhys's *Wide Sargasso Sea* (1966), the canonical palinode of *Jane Eyre*. Gaiman's version makes the lesson structural: who the monster is depends on who has been given the eyes of the tale.

Two further forms of palinode complete the pattern. "Chivalry" (1992) sets the Grail quest of Malory and Tennyson against a widow who has bought the Grail in an Oxfam shop and keeps it on her mantelpiece beside her late husband's photograph; the knight Galaad, who arrives to claim it, can obtain it only by exchange. The quest, whose logic is capture, meets domestic custody and must submit to its terms. And the memory-comics made with Dave McKean, *Violent Cases* (1987) and *Mr. Punch* (1994), are palinodes of the self. In each a narrator revisits a childhood scene of adult violence—a father's injury to his son's arm and the osteopath who had once treated Al Capone; a grandfather's seaside arcade, a Punch and Judy man and a woman performing as a mermaid—and discovers that memory has already revised it. Freud's "Über Deckerinnerungen" (1899) argued that childhood memories are constructed later, as screens; Gaiman's narrators recant their own recollections in the act of telling them, while Punch, the carnival murderer of Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (1965), kills his way through the traditional play with impunity. The self, too, is a story that must be retold to be seen.

7.3 The Dialectic of the Palinode

The palinode carries a structural danger that Gaiman's practice both exhibits and manages. Stesichorus's recantation did not exonerate Helen by complicating her story; it relocated the guilt onto a phantom, the *eidolon* for which the Greeks and Trojans died. A palinode can blind a new figure in the act of restoring an old one. "Snow, Glass, Apples" gives the Queen her eyes and turns Snow White into a monster; "A Study in Emerald" rehabilitates the revolutionaries and makes the canonical detective an agent of tyranny. Every recantation, pursued to its end, produces a new blindness.

> *Every recantation, pursued to its end, produces a new blindness.*

Gaiman's characteristic solution is accumulation rather than replacement. His retellings do not claim that the canonical versions were false, only that they were partial, and the corpus keeps every version in play at once: Snow White is both the innocent of the Grimms and the vampire of the palinode; Holmes is both the hero of the canon and the insurgent of the pastiche. This is palinode as polyphony in Mikhail Bakhtin's sense, the coexistence of unmerged voices, and it is custody at the level of narrative. The emblem of this practice is Lucien's library in the Dreaming, which shelves the books that were dreamed but never written, among them a Chesterton novel, *The Man Who Was October*, that Chesterton never wrote. The library keeps not only what was told but what might have been told; it is a custodial archive of the possible, the literary form of what Ernst Bloch called the Not-Yet.

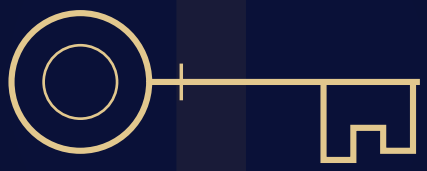
Gaiman's mythography is custodial in the same sense. *Norse Mythology* (2017) places him in the line of Ovid, Snorri, the Grimms, Andrew Lang's coloured *Fairy Books* (1889–1910), Italo Calvino's *Fiabe italiane* (1956) and Angela Carter's *Virago Book of Fairy Tales* (1990): retellers who keep a body of story by changing it. The book closes, as the *Völuspá* does, not with Ragnarök but with the renewal that follows, when "In wondrous beauty once again / Shall the golden tables stand mid the grass, / Which the gods had owned in the days of old" (trans. Bellows): the pieces of the gods' game are found in the grass by the survivors, kept through the end of the world for a new game. And *The Dream Hunters* (1999) performs the palinodic imperative in reverse. Its afterword attributed the story to Japanese sources later acknowledged to be fictitious, a Borgesian gesture in the manner of "Pierre Menard" (1939) and "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940). An invented tale was given a borrowed genealogy, as though even a new story must present itself as something received and kept rather than owned. The forgery is itself a statement of the ethic: in Gaiman's economy, no story is original property. Every story is a deposit.

CHAPTER EIGHT

A Theodicy of Story

Returning the Key

VIII



Ivan returns the ticket; Lucifer returns the key; Scheherazade goes on telling.

CHAPTER EIGHT · A THEODICY OF STORY

GAIMAN'S fiction answers the problem of evil by changing its subject. It offers no justification of God, whose Presence remains off-stage throughout the corpus, but a defence of story: suffering is neither explained nor redeemed by an ultimate end, but kept—witnessed, retold and deferred—so that in the retelling it is seen. This chapter reconstructs the problem, reads Lucifer's abdication as its most original treatment in the corpus, and proposes that the form of Gaiman's answer is Scheherazadean.

8.1 The Old Questions

The problem is ancient and its formulation fixed. Philo, in the tenth of Hume's *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion* (1779), restates it on Epicurus's behalf: "Epicurus's old questions are yet unanswered. Is he willing to prevent evil, but not able? then is he impotent. Is he able, but not willing? then is he malevolent. Is he both able and willing? whence then is evil?" Leibniz's *Essais de Théodicée* (1710) answered that this is the best of all possible worlds; Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) answered Leibniz with Pangloss; and Kant, in "Über das Mißlingen aller philosophischen Versuche in der Theodicee" (1791), declared every philosophical theodicy a failure and praised Job, who refused to flatter God, above the friends who defended Him. The divine speech from the whirlwind—"Where wast thou when I laid the foundations of the earth? declare, if thou hast understanding" (Job 38:4)—answers suffering with sublimity, not reasons; and Jung's *Antwort auf Hiob* read that speech as the evasion of a God not yet conscious of what He had done. The most uncompromising modern response is Ivan Karamazov's, who refuses a final harmony purchased with the suffering of a single child: "It's not God that I don't accept, Alyosha, only I most respectfully return Him the ticket" (*The Brothers Karamazov*, 1880, trans. Garnett).

8.2 Returning the Key

Season of Mists (1990–91) contains the corpus's most original contribution to this tradition. Lucifer Morningstar, having ruled Hell for some ten billion years, empties it of demons and damned, locks its gates, and hands the key to Dream, who has come to rescue Nada and now finds himself responsible for the disposal of Hell. Lucifer's grievance is precise. Human beings blame him for their evils, although he has never made anyone do anything; they come to his realm, the series suggests, because they believe they deserve to. Hell in this account is self-sentencing, an idea with two notable precedents: C. S. Lewis's *The Great Divorce* (1945), in which the damned choose their damnation and could leave if they would, and Sartre's *Huis clos* (1944), whose three characters discover that hell is the gaze of others. Gaiman's Hell is the gaze of guilt internalized, a capture the damned practise upon themselves.

Lucifer's refusal is also the refusal of an office that René Girard would recognize. *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) and *Le Bouc émissaire* (1982) described the scapegoat mechanism by which a community discharges its violence onto a single victim whose expulsion restores order; Gaiman's Lucifer is the cosmic scapegoat, and he resigns. The resignation revises Milton at the root. Milton's Satan declares it "Better to reign in Hell, than serve in Heav'n" (*Paradise Lost* I.263); Gaiman's Lucifer declines both to reign and to serve and takes the third course, exit, ending the arc on a beach in Western Australia watching a sunset. The parallel with Ivan is exact. Ivan returns the ticket to a harmony he cannot accept; Lucifer returns the key to a system he will no longer administer. Neither offers a theodicy. Both refuse to be its instrument.

The disposal of Hell then dramatizes theotrophy as real estate. Odin, Thor and Loki; Anubis, Bast and Bes; Susano-o; the Lords of Order and Chaos; the envoys of Faerie; and the demons who once served there all petition Dream for the vacant realm, each offering a bribe or a threat. At the Silver City's instruction Dream gives it to the angels Remiel and Duma, and Remiel resolves to make Hell a place of rehabilitation, in which the damned will be hurt for their own good. Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* traced exactly this transition, from the spectacular punishment of the body to a corrective discipline whose object is the soul, and concluded that the soul had become the prison of the body. Remiel's Hell is *therapeutic capture*, custody counterfeited, the Sleer corollary rendered as theology: a keeping that claims to serve the kept while serving the keeper's need to keep. The same arc includes the story of the dead schoolboy Charles Rowland, who stays behind at his boarding school with the ghost of Edwin Paine when the dead briefly return; the school is an institution of cruelty—older boys torture Charles until he dies, as older boys had killed Edwin in 1916—and the two dead boys' friendship is the only custody on its premises.

8.3 The Designed Wound

"Murder Mysteries" (1992) moves the problem of evil before the creation. In the Silver City, where angels design the concepts that will compose the universe, an angel engaged in the design of Death is found murdered; Raguel, the Vengeance of the Lord, whose office had awaited its first work, identifies the killer and destroys him; and the story leaves open, in Lucifer's hearing, the suspicion that the crime was permitted so that vengeance should have something to do. The Easter proclamation of the *Exsultet* sings of the *felix culpa*, the happy fault that merited so great a Redeemer; Gaiman's version is a designer's *felix culpa*, a wound engineered so that a function may exist. It is the darkest form of the Leibnizian answer, in which evil is justified as the occasion of a good, and it is presented as the seed of Lucifer's doubt. Evil, in this account, is the price a system pays for the completeness of its functions, and the first creature to notice the price is the first to rebel.

Ted Chiang's "Hell Is the Absence of God" (2001) offers the sharpest counterpoint in speculative fiction. In Chiang's world, angelic visitations strike like natural disasters, healing some and killing others arbitrarily, and the sight of Heaven's light occasionally grants perfect love of God. Neil Fisk, whose wife died in a visitation, seeks that light in order to be reunited with her; the light burns out his eyes, he loves God perfectly, and he is sent to Hell nonetheless, where he goes on loving God forever. Chiang's theodicy is Kierkegaardian and uncompromising, and its ocular emblem—love purchased with blindness—is the most extreme transaction in the ocular economy described in Chapter Four. Gaiman's cosmos lacks Chiang's God. Its angels are functionaries of an absent Presence, and its most sympathetic theologian is the devil who resigned.

8.4 The Ineffable Plan

Good Omens (1990), written with Terry Pratchett, stages the problem as comedy. Heaven and Hell are bureaucracies, each confident that a Great Plan will culminate in Armageddon; their agents on earth, the angel Aziraphale and the demon Crowley, have reached a private arrangement over six thousand years and have grown fond of the world they are meant to contest. The Antichrist, Adam Young, misplaced at birth and raised as an ordinary boy in an English village, reshapes reality in accordance with what he reads and imagines—Atlantis rises, Tibetans tunnel under the countryside, extraterrestrials land—so that theotrophy is concentrated in the regard of a single child, as it is in George Orr's effective dreams in Le Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971). The hellhound sent to him becomes a small mongrel named Dog because Adam wanted a small dog: regard remakes the beast into something that can be loved. Adam's maturation consists in renouncing the power to remake the world, and in letting it be.

The novel's theology hinges on ineffability. At its climax the question is raised whether the Great Plan and the ineffable plan are the same, and the possibility is entertained that ineffability itself may include the defiance of the written plan. Apophatic theology—Pseudo-Dionysius's *Mystical Theology*, Maimonides's doctrine of

negative attributes in the *Guide of the Perplexed* (I.58)—had made the unknowability of God a principle of reverence; Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843) had made the incommensurability of the divine and the ethical a principle of dread. *Good Omens* makes ineffability a principle of freedom. Since no one can know that the defiance of the plan is not the plan, the world may be spared. What saves it, finally, is not a revelation but a fondness. Two minor functionaries of opposed powers have attended to the world with affection for so long that they will not let it end. The world is justified by being liked.

> *"The world is justified by being liked.*

8.5 A Scheherazadean Theodicy

The form of Gaiman's answer is supplied by the frame of the *One Thousand and One Nights*. King Shahryar, betrayed, marries a woman each night and kills her at dawn: the most extreme figure of appetitive regard in world literature, consuming a life nightly. Scheherazade marries him and tells a story each night that she breaks off at dawn, so that he must keep her alive to hear its end; over a thousand nights her stories redirect his attention from appetite to narrative, and he is cured. Her storytelling is custody: of herself, of the women who would have followed her, and of the king's own humanity. It neither justifies his violence nor explains it. It defers and transforms it.

"Ramadan" (*Sandman* #50), drawn by P. Craig Russell, is the corpus's explicit homage. The caliph Harun al-Rashid, fearing that his perfect Baghdad will decay as all cities decay, sells it to Dream so that it may be preserved forever in dreams, and the waking city becomes merely a city. The frame reveals that the tale is being told to a poor boy in the Baghdad of the early 1990s, damaged by the bombing campaign of the United States–led coalition in the Gulf War of 1991. The story keeps the city in trust while history ruins it. Walter Benjamin's ninth thesis "Über den Begriff der Geschichte" (1940), with its angel of history facing the wreckage that piles up at his feet, describes the same situation from the side of history; Gaiman describes it from the side of the story that survives.

The Sandman as a whole is a Scheherazadean form. Its seventy-five monthly issues defer an ending that is announced long before it arrives, and *The Wake* is the final night. Frank Kermode's *The Sense of an Ending* (1967) argued that fictions organize time by the promise of concordant ends; Gaiman's endings are distinguished by the fact that something continues in keeping—Daniel in the Dreaming, the renewed world of the *Völuspá*, Lettie in the ocean. And Benjamin's essay "Der Erzähler" (1936) supplies the most compact formulation of the theodicy of story, in its claim that the storyteller borrows his authority from death. *The Sandman* dramatizes that claim as kinship: the

Prince of Stories is the younger brother of Death, and she is the one who sets him right. Ivan returns the ticket; Lucifer returns the key; Scheherazade goes on telling. The corpus sides with Scheherazade, and the reason is not that stories justify suffering but that, told and retold, they keep its victims in view.

CHAPTER NINE

Among the Dreamers

Gaiman in the Field of Philosophical Speculative Fiction



Fantasy of Gaiman's kind is a futurology of the past: it asks what the forgotten will do when it returns, and whether anyone will be there to keep it.

CHAPTER NINE · AMONG THE DREAMERS

GAIMAN'S economy of regard is not an idiosyncrasy but a position within a field. Read comparatively, the speculative fiction of his century returns again and again to the same four problems—the relation of dream to reality, the dependence of gods on belief, the custody of memory and care, and the visibility of the dispossessed—and on each it divides along the line this thesis has drawn between capture and custody. This chapter maps the field along those four axes and closes with a proposal about the kind of cognition fantasy performs.

9.1 Dream and Reality

The oldest text on this axis already binds dream to metamorphosis. In the second chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, Zhuang Zhou dreams that he is a butterfly and, waking, cannot tell whether he is Zhou who dreamt he was a butterfly or a butterfly dreaming it is Zhou; the passage ends by naming this condition 物化, *wuhua*, the transformation of things. Ovid and Zhuangzi, working at opposite ends of the ancient world, both place dreaming within a doctrine of universal change. The early modern West made the dream a figure of epistemic doubt: Calderón's Segismundo concludes *La vida es sueño* (1635) "que toda la vida es sueño, / y los sueños, sueños son," and Descartes's first *Meditation* (1641) makes the indistinguishability of dreaming and waking the lever of radical doubt.

The fantastic tradition converted the doubt into cosmology. Lord Dunsany's *The Gods of Pegāna* (1905) imagines a supreme god, MĀNA-YOOD-SUSHĀĪ, who sleeps and dreams the worlds, while Skarl the drummer beats unceasingly so that he will not wake; should the drumming stop, the god will wake and the worlds will end. Dunsany's cosmos is sustained by a custodian whose only task is to keep a dreamer dreaming. Lovecraft's *The Dream-Quest of Unknown Kadath* (written 1926–27) mapped the Dreamlands that the Dreaming would inherit, and Borges's "Las ruinas circulares" (1940) gave the form its vertiginous turn: a man dreams a son into existence and discovers that he himself is being dreamed. *The Sandman* absorbs all three. Daniel is a child conceived in the Dreaming; the Dreaming is shaped by those who dream; and its lord, like Borges's dreamer, exists as a function of other dreamers.

The most exact comparison is Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971). George Orr's dreams alter reality retroactively, so that the world has always been as he last dreamt it; his psychiatrist, William Haber, harnesses the power for utopian engineering, and each improvement is a catastrophe: his order to end overpopulation produces a plague that has retroactively killed some six billion people, his order to end war an alien invasion against which humanity unites, his order to end racial conflict a humanity in which every person is grey. Haber is Burgess with a clinical licence:

capture of the dream in the name of benevolence. Orr's resistance is Taoist, and the *Daodejing* states its principle with an exactness that makes it a charter of custody: 天下神器，不可為也。為者敗之，執者失之 (ch. 29)—the world is a sacred vessel that cannot be worked upon; those who work on it ruin it, and those who grasp it lose it. The verb for grasping, 執 (*zhi*), is capture. Gaiman's "A Dream of a Thousand Cats" (#18) shares Le Guin's premise—that sufficient dreamers can remake the world retroactively, so that it will always have been otherwise—and its cat-prophet preaches the capture of the world by counter-dream. Philip K. Dick supplied the premise's nightmare: in *Ubik* (1969) the half-living dead share a decaying reality in which the boy Jory devours the others to sustain himself, and in *VALIS* (1981) the Roman Empire never ended but continues as a prison of perception. Gaiman's "August" is the counter-myth, in which Augustus, invisible to the gods for one day a year, plans the Empire's limits in secret. The cinema of the twenty-first century extended the axis into technology: in Satoshi Kon's *Paprika* (2006) a device for entering patients' dreams is stolen and dreams flood the waking city, and in Christopher Nolan's *Inception* (2010) dreams are penetrated for corporate extraction. Both confirm the periodization of Chapter Four: the dream has become a resource.

> *The dream has become a resource.*

9.2 Gods and Belief

Terry Pratchett, Gaiman's collaborator, is his nearest neighbour on the second axis. *Small Gods* (1992) makes divine power a function of belief and distinguishes belief in a god from belief in the institution built upon him; *Hogfather* (1996) has Death argue, in effect, that human beings must learn to believe small fictions in order to believe the large ones, such as justice and mercy. Pratchett's theology is Feuerbachian and humanist: gods are what belief makes of them, and belief is what makes us human. Gaiman's is Jamesian and tragic: gods are real, hungry and dangerous, and belief is a metabolism that can nourish or devour.

Roger Zelazny's *Lord of Light* (1967) imagines colonists who use technology to become the Hindu pantheon and rule a planet's descendants, and a rebel who introduces Buddhism as a revolution against technological divinity: worship captured by an apparatus. William Gibson's *Count Zero* (1986) has fragments of a dispersed artificial intelligence manifest in cyberspace as Vodou loa, fifteen years before the Technical Boy; Neal Stephenson's *Snow Crash* (1992) makes Sumerian myth a neurolinguistic virus and its villain a media magnate who captures minds through it. Alan Moore's *Promethea* (1999–2005) imagines a goddess who dwells in the Immateria, the realm of imagination, and is sustained by the successive writers and artists who

imagine her: theotrophy of fiction declared outright. Jonathan Carroll's *The Land of Laughs* (1980) imagines a town brought into being by a dead writer's imagination, whose inhabitants are his characters.

Philip Pullman's *His Dark Materials* (1995–2000) offers the decisive contrast. Its Authority, an ancient angel who claimed to be the Creator, is kept in a crystal litter by his regent Metatron; released by two children, he dissolves into the air with evident relief. The image is the twin of Morpheus in Burgess's glass sphere: a frail divinity encased by those who use him, released by others, and ending. But Pullman's project is abolition, the replacement of the Kingdom of Heaven by a Republic of Heaven. Gaiman's is custodial: the gods are to be kept, differently. The most profound parallel on this axis is Octavia E. Butler's *Wild Seed* (1980). Doro, an immortal who survives by killing people and taking over their bodies, and who breeds human beings like livestock across centuries, is capture incarnate; Anyanwu, a healer who can reshape her own body at will, is metamorphosis placed in the service of care. Butler's novel is structured by precisely the antithesis this thesis finds in Gaiman, and it places metamorphosis, as Gaiman does, on the side of custody.

9.3 Memory, Care and the Artificial Custodian

On the third axis, Gene Wolfe is Gaiman's great contemporary. Severian, the narrator of *The Book of the New Sun* (1980–83), claims to forget nothing, and his hypermnesia is the opposite pole of the amnesiac returns of *The Ocean at the End of the Lane*. Wolfe's *Soldier of the Mist* (1986) supplies the missing term: Latro, a mercenary of the Persian wars, forgets everything each day, can see the gods that others cannot, and keeps a scroll so that he may read each morning who he is. He is Gaiman's amnesiac seer, and his scroll is the custodial writing of Mr. Ibis. Ted Chiang's "The Truth of Fact, the Truth of Feeling" (2013) restages the *Phaedrus* twice over, pairing a near-future technology of total recall with the arrival of writing among the Tiv of colonial Nigeria, and its narrator comes to use exact records as instruments of self-correction rather than accusation. Chiang's "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010) is the purest custody narrative in contemporary science fiction: human caretakers raise digital beings over years and must choose between preparing them for autonomy and selling copies of them to a company that would condition them to serve as sexual companions for its customers.

Kazuo Ishiguro has made custody his subject across three novels. In *Never Let Me Go* (2005), Kathy H. works as a "carer" for cloned young people who will "donate" their organs until they die: care as the gentlest face of an apparatus of capture, which is to say therapeutic capture in its secular form. *The Buried Giant* (2015) has been discussed in Chapter Five. In *Klara and the Sun* (2021), an "Artificial Friend" attends to a sick child with an attentiveness that Weil would recognize, while making devotional bargains with the Sun, the god that literally nourishes her; the adults meanwhile plan for Klara to "continue" the child should she die. Theotrophy is inverted—the god feeds the worshipper—and the machine is the Nobody-custodian in a family governed by

appetite. Susanna Clarke's *Piranesi* (2020) is the corpus's closest living kin. Its narrator lives in a House of endless halls, statues and tides, tends the skeletons of the dead with offerings and keeps meticulous journals, and has forgotten who he was; the man who keeps him there, and exploits him, is called the Other. The novel's moral structure is the one this thesis has traced from *Coraline* to *Ocean*: the Other's appetite against the Nobody's reverence. Clarke's earlier *Jonathan Strange & Mr Norrell* (2004) had given English Faerie its archetypal captor in the gentleman with the thistle-down hair, who compels his mortal victims to dance each night in his ruined hall.

9.4 The City and the Unseen

On the fourth axis, Italo Calvino's *Le città invisibili* (1972) is the acknowledged ancestor. Gaiman's "Soft Places" (#39) sends Marco Polo, lost in the desert of Lop, into a region where dream and waking overlap, a direct homage to Calvino's Polo describing imaginary cities to Kublai Khan. Calvino's book closes with Polo's counsel to seek and learn to recognize who and what, in the midst of the inferno, are not inferno, and to make them endure and give them space. There is no more exact statement of custodial enchantment in modern literature. Samuel R. Delany's *Dhalgren* (1975) sets a nameless protagonist who cannot remember his name adrift in Bellona, a city cut off from the world, a Nobody in an unseen city. China Miéville's *King Rat* (1998) located a rat kingdom beneath London two years after *Neverwhere*, and *The City & the City* (2009) made unseeing a law.

Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's *Roadside Picnic* (1972), filmed by Tarkovsky as *Stalker* (1979), explores the danger of desire in a Zone left by indifferent visitors, where a golden sphere is said to grant wishes, and its stalker ends by pleading for happiness for everyone: desire's capture and its possible redemption. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) poses the choice that *American Gods* answers at Lakeside, where a town's prosperity is purchased with the murder of a child each winter. Le Guin's moral heroes walk away; N. K. Jemisin's reply, "The Ones Who Stay and Fight" (2018), insists on remaining to resist. Shadow, in 2001, had already taken Jemisin's side, and added a third act, the recovery of the dead. Dan Simmons's *Hyperion* (1989) and Gaiman's *Worlds' End* (1993) both revived the frame narrative of Chaucer and Boccaccio, gathering travellers to tell tales in a suspended time; both suggest that under conditions of catastrophe the telling of stories is itself a form of shelter.

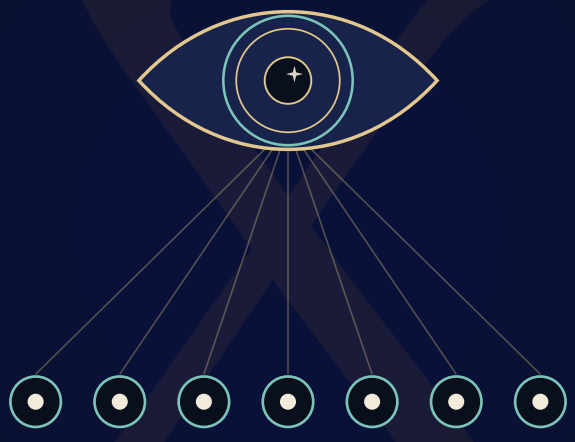
9.5 The Vetum: Toward a Theory of Anamnestic Cognition

Darko Suvin's *Metamorphoses of Science Fiction* (1979) defined science fiction by its *cognitive estrangement*, produced by a *novum*, a new thing validated by rational extrapolation, and dismissed fantasy as anti-cognitive. The comparison conducted in this chapter suggests a correction. Gaiman's estrangement is produced not by the new but by the persistence of the old: gods in motels, a medieval polity beneath the Underground, a family of women older than the moon living on a Sussex farm. This thesis proposes to name that element the *vetum* (from *vetus*, old): an archaic survival that estranges the present by revealing the depths it has forgotten. Where the novum drives an extrapolative cognition, the vetum drives an *anamnestic* one—knowledge by recollection, in the Platonic sense of the *Meno*. Fredric Jameson called science fiction an archaeology of the future. Fantasy of Gaiman's kind is its chiastic counterpart, a futurology of the past: it asks what the forgotten will do when it returns, and whether anyone will be there to keep it.

CHAPTER TEN

Devolved Providence

Toward a Custodial Poetics



Where providence looked forward from above, custody looks again from alongside.

CHAPTER TEN · DEVOLVED PROVIDENCE

THE argument of the preceding chapters can now be stated as a single thesis. Gaiman's cosmos is Berkeley's after Nietzsche: a world in which *esse est percipi* still holds, but in which the divine Perceiver who guaranteed the being of unperceived things has died. In such a world being becomes precarious and economically distributed across finite regarders, and the office that providence once discharged devolves upon creatures. Gaiman's fiction is the imaginative working-out of this *devolved providence*, and its ethics, aesthetics and politics follow from it.

10.1 Berkeley after Nietzsche

George Berkeley's *Treatise Concerning the Principles of Human Knowledge* (1710) held that the existence of sensible things consists in their being perceived: "Their esse is percipi, nor is it possible they should have any existence out of the minds or thinking things which perceive them" (§3). The obvious objection—that things would then flicker out of existence whenever no one was looking—Berkeley met with God. In the *Three Dialogues between Hylas and Philonous* (1713), Philonous reasons that since sensible things do not depend on his own perception, "there must be some other mind wherein they exist"; the tree in the empty college quadrangle persists, as the limerick later attributed to Ronald Knox has it, because God is always about. Berkeley's idealism is thus a theory of providence as perception. God's ceaseless regard is what keeps the unregarded in being.

Nietzsche's madman announced the death of that regarder. Combine the two propositions—being is being-perceived; the guarantor of perception is dead—and the result is the metaphysics of Gaiman's fiction exactly. The Presence of *The Sandman* never appears; the God of *Good Omens* is ineffable and silent; the God of "Murder Mysteries" speaks only to engineer a wound. Where the guaranteeing eye has closed, whatever finite minds cease to attend to begins to fade: the gods of *American Gods* thin into con men and die of neglect; the people of London Below drop out of the visible city; the dead of the graveyard persist only while they are remembered and visited; Nunyunnini simply stops. Theotrophy is the metabolic form of an orphaned idealism.

The ethical consequence is the one this thesis has traced through every chapter. If no infinite regard sustains what finite regard neglects, then responsibility for the unregarded passes to finite regarders. Providence devolves. The etymology states the transformation precisely. *Providentia* derives from *pro-videre*, to see ahead, to foresee and so provide; *regard*, as the Introduction showed, derives from *re-garder*, to look again, to keep watch. Where providence looked forward from above, custody looks again from alongside. Gaiman's custodians are the creaturely remainder of providence:

Death receiving each life with the attention once promised to the fallen sparrow; the Hempstocks keeping a boy's memory in reserve; the dead of the graveyard raising a child they will release; Mr. Ibis writing down the arrivals no one else recorded; the Zorya keeping their watch; Barbie writing a name in lipstick on a stone. None of them is omniscient, and none can guarantee anything. Each keeps something in being by attending to it.

10.2 The System

The metaphysics can be reconstructed as a small system of axioms, theorems and corollaries, each of which has been argued in the body of the thesis.

Axiom I, Theotrophy. To be is to be regarded: the persistence of any being—god, person, place or story—is metabolically dependent upon the attention it receives, whether as belief, memory, narration or sight. *Axiom II, Metamorphosis.* Regard is mutable; therefore whatever persists in being regarded must change, and rigidity is a mode of starvation. *Axiom III, Custody.* Regard is finite and forgetting is the default condition of finite minds, the river *Amelēs* whose water no vessel can hold; therefore the highest ethical act is fiduciary regard, the holding in trust of what attention has abandoned, for the sake of its continuance and eventual release.

Two definitions follow. *Capture* is appetitive regard, which holds a being for the consumption of the one who holds it; *custody* is fiduciary regard, which holds a being for its own sake or the world's. Since their acts are identical, they are distinguished only by their end, and the criterion of the distinction is the question: whose appetite does this keeping serve?

Three theorems can then be derived. The *Morphean Paradox* follows from the second axiom applied to a being whose identity consists in its form: the shaper of forms cannot receive a new form without ceasing to be itself, so that the only metamorphosis available to it is succession, in which the function passes, like Nāgasena's flame, to one who is neither the same nor another. The *theorem of the Nobody* follows from the first and third axioms: because the source of capture is the regarder's own appetite, the optimal regarder is one emptied of appetite—negatively capable, nameless, apophatic—and the fiction's Nobodies are accordingly its truest keepers. The *palinodic imperative* follows from all three: since stories distribute regard, a story that has withheld regard from its figures incurs a debt, and since stories can change, the debt is payable by retelling.

Four corollaries complete the system. The *Sleer corollary* holds that custody which forgets its end in release degenerates into capture, as Remiel's rehabilitative Hell and the dragon's hoard both show. The *Scheherazadean corollary* holds that suffering in story is neither justified nor explained but kept—witnessed, retold and deferred—so that its victims remain in view. The *corollary of the vetum* holds that fantasy's characteristic cognition is anamnestic rather than extrapolative: it knows by remembering what the present has forgotten. And the *corollary of the keeper* holds that a custodial poetics which assigns the labour of custody to one class of beings captures

its keepers; the corpus violates this corollary most visibly in its gendering of care, and a critical reading must say so.

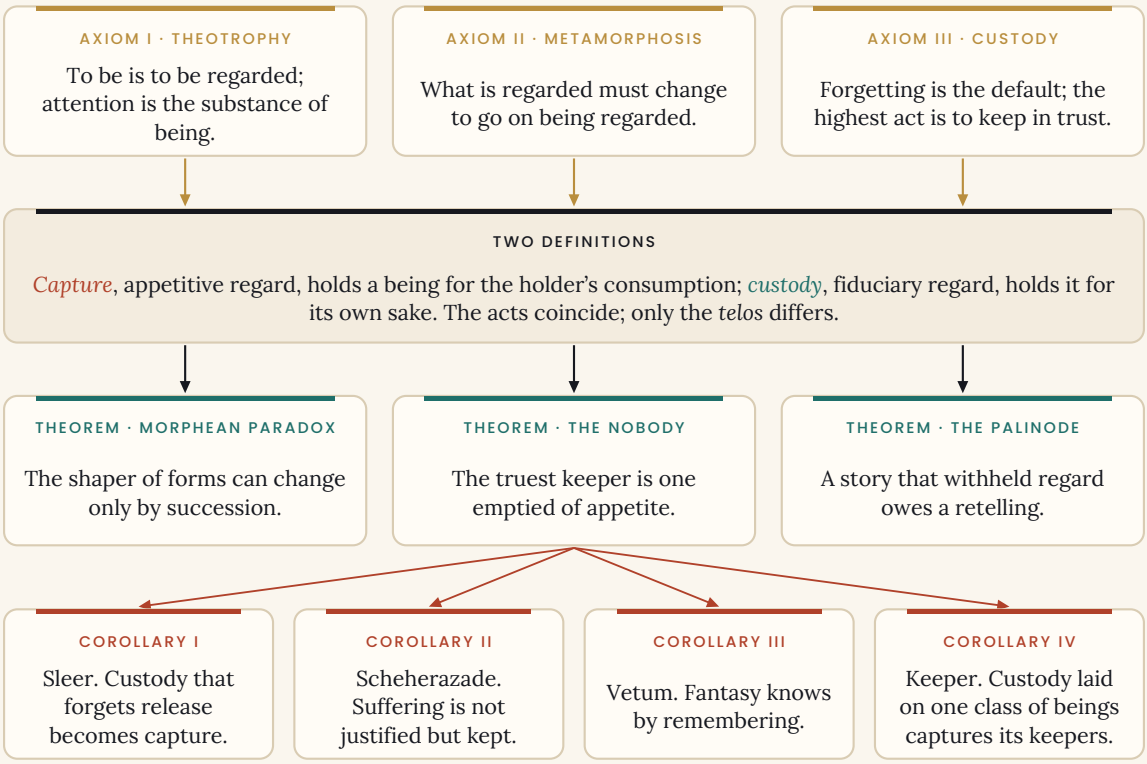


FIGURE 4 *The system of devolved providence: three axioms, two definitions, three theorems, four corollaries.*

10.3 Custodial Enchantment against Captology

The system has a historical addressee. In the 1990s the psychologist B. J. Fogg named the study of computers as persuasive technologies *captology*, and his *Persuasive Technology* (2003) became a founding text of the design practices that now organize the attention economy. The coinage derives from an acronym, but its accidental echo of *capture* is apt. The techniques it inaugurated—variable rewards, endless feeds, frictionless continuation—offer the user something very close to the Other Mother's bargain: an attentiveness perfectly adapted to one's wishes, purchased at the cost of one's own capacity to look elsewhere. *Coraline* is, among other things, a parable of the platform.

Against captology, Gaiman's fiction practises a custodial technology. It too holds attention—it is, after all, commercial fiction of enormous reach—but its narratives are designed to return attention to the world rather than to retain it: to the homeless on the pavement, the dead in the churchyard, the forgotten sister, the god no one visits. Bernard Stiegler's *Prendre soin de la jeunesse et des générations* (2008) argued that the culture industries' "psychopower" destroys the capacity for attention and that technics, as a *pharmakon*, can be turned from poison to remedy only through

deliberate practices of care; Gaiman's fiction is such a practice in narrative form. Jonathan Crary's defence of sleep as the last unmonetized interval finds in *The Sandman* its mythic charter. And Gaiman's own lecture for the Reading Agency (2013), arguing that fiction builds empathy by lodging readers in other minds and that libraries and daydreaming are civic necessities, states the programme in the idiom of public advocacy.

Custodial enchantment is, in this light, the corpus's answer to Weber that avoids both of the standard replies. It is not re-enchantment, which asks for belief and thereby returns to theotrophy's appetitive economy. Nor is it secular resignation, which accepts that the unregarded must fade. It is a practice: the cultivation of a wonder whose object is precariousness and whose outcome is care. Its motto is Calvino's, from the last page of *Invisible Cities*: learn to recognize what, in the midst of the inferno, is not inferno, and make it endure, and give it space.

10.4 Objections and Replies

Three objections must be answered. The first holds that *regard* is too capacious a category, explaining everything and therefore nothing. The reply is that the distinction between capture and custody yields discriminating results. It predicts that the corpus's antagonists will be appetitive regarders and its guardians fiduciary ones, and they are—from Burgess, Madoc, the Corinthian, Bilquis, the Other Mother, Ursula Monkton, Hinzelmann and the man Jack to Death, the Hempstocks, Silas, Mr. Ibis and the Zorya. More tellingly, it explains the cases that resist simple sorting: Dream, a custodian who captures; the Corinthian, a captor remade as a custodian; Remiel, whose custody is counterfeit; the Sleer, whose custody has decayed. And it identifies the corpus's failures—the gendering of care, the silencing of Indigenous presence—as failures by its own measure rather than by an external standard.

The second objection holds that custodial enchantment is conservative, a preservationist nostalgia for old gods and old stories. The reply is that custody, as defined here, is teleologically bound to release and axiomatically bound to change. The graveyard keeps Bod in order to send him out; the Dreaming survives its lord only by succession; the palinode keeps a story alive by altering it. Custody is not preservation but Spenser's dilation: things kept so that, by their change, their being may expand.

> *Custody is not preservation but Spenser's dilation.*

The third objection concerns the author-function. Can an ethic of custody be derived from a corpus whose author has been accused by several women of rape, sexual assault and coercion, in several cases within relationships of steep inequality, allegations he denies? The ethic's validity does not depend on its author's conduct; to

argue otherwise would commit the genetic fallacy, and it would also hand the ethic to anyone who wished to discredit it by discrediting a person. But the hermeneutics of custody, applied reflexively, imposes a further obligation. A reader who keeps these texts must also keep in view the testimony of those who say they were harmed, neither adjudicating it nor looking away from it, since a custody that averts its eyes from what it would rather not see has already become the Sleer. The texts' own criterion requires no less.

CONCLUSION

Cura Teneat

Hyginus's Fable of Care and the Charter of the Oeuvre



Cura teneat, quamdiu vixerit.

Let Care hold him as long as he lives.

CONCLUSION · CURA TENEAT

THE mythic charter of Gaiman's oeuvre is a fable he has never retold. It is the two hundred and twentieth of the *Fabulae* attributed to Hyginus, a Latin handbook of myths compiled in the early centuries of the common era, and it concerns a goddess named Care. Crossing a river, Cura sees a bed of clay, takes some up, and thoughtfully begins to shape a human being. Jupiter passes, and at her request gives the figure spirit. Cura wishes to give the creature her own name; Jupiter insists it should bear his; and Tellus, the Earth, rises to claim that it should be named for her, since she furnished its body. The three take Saturn, who is Time, as judge, and his verdict is exact. Jupiter, who gave the spirit, will receive the spirit at death; Earth, who gave the body, will receive the body; and because Cura first shaped the creature, she shall have it for as long as it lives. As for the disputed name, the creature shall be called *homo*, because it was made from *humus*, the soil.

Every element of the fable has appeared in this thesis. Cura is the Shaper, the one who first gives form, and her material is river clay, as Ovid's House of Sleep stands over a river of forgetting. The quarrel over the name is the onomastic ethic of Chapter Six, in which to name is to claim and the most fitting name is the humblest: the creature is named for the dirt, as Bod is named Nobody. Saturn, who judges, is Time, and in *Overture* Time is revealed to be the father of Dream; his judgement allots each claimant its portion as Destiny reads each life from his book. Jupiter and Tellus, who reclaim spirit and body at the end, divide between them the office of Gaiman's Death. And the verdict assigns the living creature neither to spirit, the realm of belief in which the hungry gods feed, nor to matter, the realm of Earth, but to Care. The fable adjudicates the economy of regard. While a being lives, it belongs to the one who keeps it.

Heidegger placed the fable at the centre of *Sein und Zeit* (1927, §42), as a pre-ontological testimony that the being of Dasein is *Sorge*, care. The Latin he reproduces, drawn from a versified redaction, differs by one word from Hyginus's prose. In Hyginus, Saturn rules that Care is to *possess* the creature: *quamdiu vixerit Cura eum possideat*. In Heidegger's version she is to *hold* it: *Cura enim quia prima finxit, teneat quamdiu vixerit*—because Care first shaped him, let Care hold him as long as he lives. The textual tradition itself oscillates between the two relations this thesis has distinguished. *Possidere* is to sit upon, to own, to occupy: the verb of capture. *Tenere* is to hold, to keep, to sustain: the verb of custody. Gaiman's corpus can be read, in its entirety, as the long argument for *teneat* against *possideat*—for a care that holds the creature without owning it, keeps it without consuming it, and at the end yields it to the claimants that time appoints.

The contributions of this study may be restated briefly. It has named *theotrophy* the metabolism by which regard sustains being, and *abaliety* the dependent realism that results, distinct from both Feuerbachian projection and classical aseity. It has returned Morpheus to Ovid and formulated the *Morphean Paradox*, reading *The Sandman* as the arc of a warden who must die to become a guardian. It has read the Endless as a table of the transcendental conditions of finite experience organized around a vacant centre; assembled the *ocular economy* from Hoffmann's eye-thief to Coraline's buttons; theorized *custodial enchantment* as Gaiman's answer to Weber; described the *Nobody* as the corpus's ideal regarder and indicted the gendering of the custodial labour that sustains him; defined the *palinodic imperative* and the *Scheherazadean* theodicy of story; proposed the *vetum* as fantasy's anamnestic counterpart to Suvin's novum; and synthesized the whole as *devolved providence*, the ethics of a Berkeleyan world whose guarantor has died. Its master distinction—capture and custody, discriminated not by act but by end—is offered as a tool for reading well beyond Gaiman, wherever fiction imagines what it means to hold another being in regard.

The corpus supplies two final images for that distinction. The first is the ocean at the end of the lane: a totality small enough to be mistaken for a duck pond, in which a girl who gave herself for a boy is healing, and in which the boy's memory of her is kept for him until he can bear it, in defiance of the river whose water no vessel can hold. The second is the close of the *Völuspá*, which Gaiman's *Norse Mythology* follows: after the gods have fallen and the world has burned and risen green again from the sea, the survivors find in the grass the golden game-pieces the gods once played with, kept through the end of everything, waiting for a new game to begin. Neither image promises that anything will be saved by a power above it. Both show something kept by those who stayed. *Cura teneat, quamdiu vixerit.*

INDEX TERMS

Keywords

works · concepts · persons, figures, and authors

Neil Gaiman · *The Sandman* · *American Gods* · *Coraline* · *Neverwhere* · *The Graveyard Book* · *The Ocean at the End of the Lane* · mythopoesis · comparative mythology · philosophy of religion · theotrophy · abaliety · dependent realism · economy of regard · attention economy · ethics of attention · capture and custody · fiduciary regard · custodial enchantment · devolved providence · disenchantment and re-enchantment · Berkeleyan idealism · death of God · Ovid · metamorphosis · Morpheus · Morphean Paradox · sacral kingship and succession · personification allegory · the Endless · transcendental imagination · the uncanny · ocular economy · gaze theory · negative capability · apophatic subjectivity · the Nobody · onomastics and naming · palinode · revisionist fairy tale · theodicy · narrative identity · memory and forgetting · anamnesis · Lethe · ethics of care · heterotopia · liminality · the trickster · psychogeography · sequential art · comics studies · fantasy theory · the vetum · cognitive estrangement · philosophical speculative fiction · Ursula K. Le Guin · Philip K. Dick · Octavia E. Butler · Ted Chiang · Terry Pratchett · Susanna Clarke · Kazuo Ishiguro · China Miéville · Jorge Luis Borges



Cura teneat, quamdiu vixerit.

Let Care hold him as long as he lives.

Set in Lora and Poppins, with DejaVu Serif and WenQuanYi Zen Hei for Greek and Chinese.
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